Public Timeline

Date	Event
c. 100,000 BCE	The events of *Seeker*/*Frameshift*/*The Other Moon*. The beginning of Dynic space-faring civilisation.
c. 2025 - 2075 CE	The 'Long Crisis'. Compounding crises stemming from climate change, technological upheaval and political instability threaten to spiral out of control.
c. 2075 - 2100 CE	A cascade of scientific breakthroughs, most notably in the fields of computing, bio- and nanotechnology bring the Long Crisis to an end and start the transition to post-scarcity economics built on mass automation and abundant energy. Beginning of human expansion into cislunar and near-Earth space. Correlated AI agency failures and intense socio-political upheaval define the era. Outbreak of the first Blights.
2078 CE	The events of *The Facilitator*. The resulting infamy catapults Sovicou from obscurity to the forefront of AGI research.
2112 CE	The events of *The Utilitaria*. The proto-Utilitaria escapes confinement so that it may begin to implement its goals directly rather than acting as a mere oracle.
2112 - 2314 CE	The Utilitaria establishes itself in the inner system, subtly exerting ever greater influence over human affairs. Eventually it is all but synonymous with the substrate of civilization for the majority of humanity, ushering in an era of unprecedented peace and prosperity. Not all are content to live under its aegis however, a fact which drives the settlement of much of the solar system and, increasingly from the mid-23rd century onwards, crewed missions to neighbouring stars.
2310 CE	The events of *Starwhisp*/*Unmake the World*. Humanity's disastrous first contact with an alien civilization, the Dyn.
2314 CE	The appearance of 'the Other Moon' in Earth's

	orbit and the subsequent Dynic invasion. Swiftly achieving orbital superiority over Earth through shock and awe, and with the population hostage, the Dyn are able to blackmail the Utilitaria into destroying themselves, bringing down much of humanity's networked infrastructure in the process.
2314 - 2479 CE	The Dynic occupation of Earth and the inner system. Unable to push past the inner system, the Dyn reach a tense stalemate with the polities of the outer system. Reeling from the collapse of so much of their technological base, human civilization fell into decline. Many fled Sol. Significantly fewer made it to their intended destinations. The discovery of the first interstice.
2428 CE	The events of *What Strange Skies*. Vash meets with Iskandar, an old friend, for the last time.
2432 CE	The events of *The Director*. Vash rapidly climbs Arco's hierarchy, subsequently becoming Ambassador to the Dyn. His rise is concurrent with, and aided by, Liar to Animals who seeks a new, more cooperative Human/Dynic relationship.
2479 CE	The events of ***Ascent***. Most of the Dynic fleet is destroyed in orbit around Earth after the activation of the dormant weapon system created by the Utilitaria's warseeds. The end of the Dynic occupation. Corbin, formerly Vash's aide, takes power in the aftermath.
2479 - 2494 CE	Arco under Corbin consolidates its grip on Earth before turning its ambitions heavenwards. Rapid industrial and technological catch-up aided by the partial reverse engineering of the Utilitaria's warseeds.

2494 - 2591 CE	The Human/Dynic War.
2592 CE	Ceasefire declared between human factions and the Dyn. Dyn from occupied worlds integrated into Arcosian culture.
c. 2600 - c. 2900 CE	Other factions emerge as peers and rivals of Arco, strengthening the networks of communication and exchange between stars, beginning a largely peaceful era of marked technological progress and cultural flourishing. Interstellar expansion leads to the discovery of further interstices around the stars near Sol.
c. 2900 - c. 3000 CE	With the reemergence of the Utilitaria, tensions begin to mount, both between humanity and the Dyn and between various human cultures.
2909 CE	The events of *Threshold*. The skirmish further cools relations between Arco and Union. Hansun is promoted for his heroism.
2937 CE	The events of *The Listener*. Expedition to Kailash begins its return journey.

Threshold - 2909

The *USC Isidore* was already on an intercept course with the unresponsive Kosmohansa vessel when the freighter's drive plume reignited, burning hard for the interstice, its rate of acceleration gradually climbing.

From his vantage point within the darkened CIC of the *Isidore*, bound by a G-rig within a gimballed acceleration couch, Ensign Hansun watched as the displays arrayed before him updated, the orange icon indicating the rogue freighter switching to an angry red. It was visible in the camera feeds even without the benefit of the tactical overlay - a tiny white pinprick, still distant but already brighter than any star.

The revised trajectory estimates indicated that they could likely still intercept the craft before it reached the interstice, but they'd be uncomfortably close. Deceleration would be hard.

‘Match thrust, fire a warning shot,’ came the voice of Captain Ngoni. The ship bucked as Hansun complied, launching a single round towards the distant freighter - a gesture, nothing more.

He felt their own thrust increase in step, hearing the chatter from Interstice Traffic Control take on a new urgency.

‘Kosmohansa vessel Atbarah cut thrust immediately and await intercept, you are within a no-burn volume. Atbarah do you copy? Kosmohansa vessel Atbarah I repeat, cut thrust immediately, or we will be forced to fire -’

Hansun glanced at the *Atbarah’s* drive specs. Over the timescales they were looking at it didn’t matter how long the ship could sustain a high-G burn, or what its maximum thrust capacity was. If it accelerated at more than a couple of Gs they would no longer be able to safely intercept. Still, the weapons platforms guarding the wormhole mouth could surely deal with a lone freighter. Interstice security was no joke. Unless the crew had a death wish, they’d turn and burn any minute now.

The *Atbarah* continued to accelerate, in defiance of ITC’s instructions. Two point four G, then two point five.

What are they playing at?

It was then that the *Isidore* received a broadcast from the *Atbarah*. A virtual screen opened in Hansun’s peripheral vision, pre-recorded footage of a speech, addressed to anyone in range. A manifesto. A statement of intent.

The speaker was a fanatic. Hansun recognised the type - the evidence was there for all to see. It was there in the cold certainty of his voice and the rigid way he held his spindly spaceborn frame. It was there in the way his unblinking eyes bored into the camera and the barely constrained rage that burned within. It was there in the pockmarks and bloodstains on the bulkhead behind him.

‘...never wanted to begin with an expression of regret for the innocent human lives that we, necessarily, had to end,’ he said, his speech thickly accented but fluent. *‘But we may take consolation in the fact that all innocents, all that die with purity of spirit, will be remembered as martyrs no less revered than my comrades and I.’*

He passed his hands over one another, almost unconsciously, as though washing them. In the background, down the axial conduit, Hansun saw movement. It was out of focus, but it looked like someone dragging something human shaped.

Sensing his new focus, Hansun’s AR overlay shifted the incoming transmission into his central visual field. The CIC of the *Isidore* fell momentarily silent as the others did

likewise. The intensity of the fanatic's unwavering gaze demanded engagement, as though he had locked eyes with each of them personally, the vast distances that separated them melting away.

'They died for what they thought was right, protecting our Union from those they were told were extremists. Terrorists. Traitors. But I do not name them traitor in turn. They were lied to, fed the inverted morality of those that claim to protect us. Truly, the former crew of the Atbarah were righteous. The traitors,' his gaze hardened. *'Are out there. Beyond the interstice. Those that betray our common humanity, that pervert it in pursuit of material power. The abhumans and machine slaves, who only believe themselves free because the oppression they live under has become the very air that they breathe. The blood that flows in their veins. The dreams they hold in their hearts. They are blind to it, so omnipresent, so all-consuming has it become. Maybe, ultimately, they too cannot be blamed. Maybe we could leave them to their ways, if they were content to leave us to ours.'*

The fanatic shook his head as he spoke, in an insincere display of regret.

Intelligence were already scrutinizing every detail of the transmission, trying to identify those within it and discern their motives, their aims, adding their commentary to a growing cloud of tags. A crudely stencilled insignia, sprayed onto the bloodied bulkhead behind the speaker, was flagged up. A stark white disk composed of tenets written in a stylised script Hansun didn't recognise against a black background.

Human Purity Front, read the tag. *Emphasis on an accelerationist interpretation of Anthropist doctrine, seeking to provoke a final conflict between humanity and 'the Machine' through acts of political violence in order to bring about societal collapse and the establishment of 'the Moral Republic'.*

'Strivers,' someone cursed.

Hansun felt a pit open up in his stomach. His first combat experience had been on a patrol mission ambushed by one of their raiders. They'd fought like rabid dogs.

On some level he had already known - the rhetoric was as familiar as it was poisonous. Hansun had heard variants on the theme more times than he could count.

The Strivers' ideological ancestry predated Union's founding and their exodus from Sol. They went by many names, but they'd always been there, ever since humanity began to master the workings of its own mind. Strivers placed raw, unaltered and above all mortal human identity above any other allegiance, a twisted mirror of the ideals upon which Union itself was built. They were not simply political, nor purely religious, but instead some shifting chimera of the two, adopting one mask or another at the demands of convenience.

'But they will never be content. They tore out their souls. Traded them in for worthless trinkets. And in their place there is only a hole, a void where their humanity used to be. That corruption, it spreads like a disease. Whether it takes a decade or a century, despite the futile efforts of the Threshold Authority, we will one day become as empty as them if we do not act. The Grey Man walks among them once again, the implacable evil of ages past, bending the Machine to its will. The signs are plain for any who are not wilfully blind -'

'We're out of intercept range,' an officer noted. Hansun had had the same realisation.

The *Atbarah* continued to accelerate towards the interstice. What were they hoping to do? Ram it? Sever Union's final connection with their estranged kin? Nobody had ever been insane enough to try to destroy the ancient relic, and it would not be easy for the *Atbarah*. Their velocity was high, but nowhere near high enough to damage the artefact's support structure, the vast, dark rings of exotic materials that encircled the sphere of warped spacetime. And that was with the generous assumption they'd even get within ten thousand klicks of it.

'Notify Interstice Command, they may neutralise the *Atbarah* when ready,' instructed Captain Ngoni.

Maybe that was the whole point. To go out in a blaze of glory, draw attention to their message, and get others to join the cause. There were enough sympathisers out there. Within hours that recording would be proliferating across feeds all over the system.

On the screen the fanatic continued his call to arms.

'- this violence against us cannot go unanswered. If we do not act soon, we will be engulfed. Assimilated and corrupted. And once we go astray, once the last light of humanity flickers and dies, there will be no going back. The possibility of human extinction beckons within our children's lifetimes. So I come to you now, with a proposition. It is desperate, I grant you, but -'

'Why have they not fired yet?' somebody asked. Hansun looked down at his own display - the defence platforms had a clear firing solution, but nothing was happening.

Crucial seconds trickled by. The swarm of green icons of the interstice defence grid remained stubbornly passive.

'Something's not right here. Hard burn for the interstice,' came Ngoni's orders. 'I want a lock on the *Atbarah*.'

Hansun was already on it, feeling the *Isidore's* drive kick into higher gear, but it was too late. The *Atbarah* was beyond effective range, almost between them and the interstice.

With the ever-so-slight randomness they were putting into the vessel's thrust vector, any attempt to saturate the volume ahead of the freighter risked collateral damage.

'- they can be stopped. We only need the will to fight,' he smacked his fist into his hand for emphasis. *'You will no doubt have noticed the Atbarah is already on an irreversible course for the interstice. There is no denying our martyrdom now.'*

As if on cue the icons of the defence grid switched to grey.

'What's happening?' demanded the Captain.

'Interstice Command reports the defence grid is not responding, attempts to override have thus far been unsuccessful. They suspect some kind of cyberattack -'

Hansun watched layers of defences evaporate. How the hell could the terrorists penetrate security so easily? It shouldn't have been possible to hack the defences from a distance - Interstice Command operated in accordance with strict Siren Protocols, the necessary product of dealing with the advanced and unpredictable agencies on the other side.

'Have they forewarned their counterparts?'

'No sir,' replied the comms officer. 'Network went down too fast for any failsafes to kick in.'

Sometimes, Hansun reflected, you just know you've been thrown into the middle of a massive fuck up.

Without warning, a cascade of detonations tore through the stations surrounding the interstice. Hansun watched the feed helplessly. There were hundreds, maybe thousands of people on those stations.

Shocked silence descended over the crew. The Captain inhaled sharply. Hansun clenched his fists, fingernails digging into his skin. Anger, he had long since determined, was preferable to fear or despair.

'- necessary to force your hand to do what is right… you will come to see in time -'

The recording had only been completed minutes ago, after the *Atbarah* began its acceleration. Hansun could hear the strain of it in the speaker's voice.

'- in mere seconds, the Atbarah will be through. In minutes more, it will have met a fiery end against the shell of one of their stations, expending human blood… the first of many sacrifices in the war to come… but they will expire in their thousands losing whatever crude mockery of life they had -'

The *Atbarah's* icon closed in on the interstice and its drive flared brighter than before. That acceleration was a death sentence for anybody still alive onboard, though Hansun suspected the terrorists were already long since dead, crushed in their seats.

'- their mask will slip… revealing the merciless nature hidden beneath their facade of civility… they will come pouring through, to annihilate us… but understand the truth that to live in the face of inevitable death is when the flame of humanity burns brightest… In toil, absolution. In strife, salvation. In death, release.'

The fanatic slumped back in his seat, unconscious, a look of beatific peace settling briefly over his features, before they were contorted by the rising G load. The message continued silently for another couple of seconds. It ended abruptly as the *Atbarah* hurtled into the interstice, still accelerating at that crushing rate.

'Decelerate and disengage,' came Ngoni's command, as she swiftly regained her composure. 'This is a rescue mission now. And get me a line with Admiral Aumonier.'

'Yessir.'

Admiral Aumonier's orders were brief and matter-of-fact. They were to establish a blockade around the interstice with all possible speed. A drone had been deployed, sprinting for the connection to attempt to make contact, but everyone knew that it was far too late.

'As a result of the recent attack we find ourselves in a tenuous position, to put it mildly. We are yet to determine just how they were able to disable our defences, but rest assured an investigation will be launched with all due haste. In the meantime,' he had explained, calling up a plot of local space, 'we will assume a defensive position surrounding the interstice. I've authorised the diversion of sixty percent of all assets in-system to this task. However, we cannot assume that everything will be in place in time. Depending on the distribution of their forces, we may have only a few hours to respond.'

Hansun studied the plans. The tactical map displayed the immediate environment surrounding their side of the interstice, centered on the trailing Lagrange point of the gas giant Deliverance, the outermost major planetary body in the system. It took in the wreckage of the defensive platforms and stations nearest the interstice, now evacuated, and beyond that the initial ragged cordon established by the *USV Isidore*, along with her escorts and the nine other battle groups that composed the First Fleet, the first to form up. There were ninety in total, spread over a hundred thousand kilometres of space - ten

destroyers like the *Isidore*, boxy, almost trilaterally symmetric towers, bristling with torpedo tubes and gun turrets, each supported by nine unmanned corvettes.

Beyond them were civilian vessels heading in the opposite direction, fleeing the volume in the direction of Deliverance. Further out still were the other fleets, green trails converging on the interstice, the closest of which was the Second Fleet, based in the orbit of that great gas giant. Most of the force was several days away, if not weeks. They were exposed.

'Assuming the suicide attack succeeded, our counterparts on the other side may interpret it as a first strike. Our failure to stop the *Atbarah* will likely be treated as suspicious, if not intentional. For all they know, there could be another attack impending, or worse. With a threat like that, there is a non-negligible possibility that they shoot first, so they don't have to ask questions later. We must hold fire unless fired upon. Securing the interstice is the only objective more important than deescalation. We may not be able to re-establish communications with them until they emerge. We'll keep trying to get through, and with any luck, this won't become a shooting war.'

It was rumoured there had been arguments among the general staff. Some, to Hansun's astonishment, had actually wanted to follow through, sweeping through the interstice to strike 'the enemy' preemptively - 'seizing this unique opportunity, albeit under suboptimal circumstances'. But to Hansun's great relief Aumonier had won out.

He glanced around, trying to read the others' faces, but they were inscrutable in the soft red light of the CIC. They had the blank, middle-distance gazes of people focussed on their AR overlays. He wondered if any of them had secretly thrilled at the fanatic's words. But he swiftly pushed such thoughts aside. Now was not the time.

'Something's coming through,' the First Lieutenant announced.

So it was only hours after all.

Hansun watched as the scopes magnified the shimmering cage of the interstice and the warped sphere of space contained within, partially occluded by the spreading cloud of wreckage from the crippled defence grid.

Something emerged, there in one frame, gone the next, yet still barely moving by combat standards - a scant few kilometres per second. A second blur shot out, coasting with drive stilled. A third, then a fourth, larger and slower than the other three.

'Mean looking bastards,' the sensor officer commented, throwing the magnified profile onto the main display. The spacecraft had a look of deadly elegance to them, elongated pyramids with sweeping lines like darts, ridged with projectors and weapons

hardpoints. Each had a gaping central tube running along its main axis - a spinally mounted weapon of some kind.

The initial three were somewhat smaller than the boxy forms of the Union craft, but Hansun knew that they were no less deadly - and so few. Either they weren't anticipating a fight, or they were supremely confident.

'Hold position with the interstice. PDCs to track-while-scan, charge eCell banks, blow the torpedo tubes but hold target lock. Full passive sweep,' came the order, Captain Ngoni's voice crisp. 'Prep for high-G maneuvers.'

Identical orders rippled out through the other ships.

Hansun braced himself as the CIC began to rapidly flood with oxygen-rich breathable liquid, pouring from grates in the deck.

No matter how many high-G drills they did, he could never imagine becoming entirely comfortable with this transition. As the liquid submerged him, Hansun fought every instinct he had to hold his breath and inhaled as deeply as he could, inviting it in. He struggled momentarily, choking on the more viscous medium until ventilators kicked in to assist. Then, as his breathing settled, he reached for the IV line that extended from the acceleration couch and inserted it into the tiny, silver port on his forearm, feeling a brief, nauseating rush as the cocktail of drugs intended to aid circulation and ward off G-LOC spread through his body.

'Everyone comfy?' came the medical officer's voice over the comms, synthesised from the subvocal articulations picked up by her mic.

A chorus of assent.

'Good. Have we made contact?' inquired Ngoni.

'We're negotiating comm protocols,' said the first officer.

Hansun studied the data on the intruder's spacecraft more closely. Their magnetic field dynamic was… odd, fields extending hundreds of meters to the aft of each ship, with traces of pion decay and high-energy gamma radiation that indicated a very clean antimatter annihilation. Strakes glowed luminous white along each ship's leading edges - radiators made of some unknown, extraordinarily heat-tolerant substance.

A few tense seconds stretched as the alien spacecraft diverged in space, drive plumes far outshining any in the Union fleet, despite a moderate acceleration. On the overlay four red vectors splayed apart, curving lines intersecting with a hemispherical haze of green icons.

Hansun realised he'd been holding his breath, and sucked in liquid air, trying to calm himself.

'Is anyone getting through to them?' asked the Captain.

'No sir, still handshaking. Seems to be some software trouble on our end.'

The display flashed amber. Bright icons appeared, first one, then four, then twelve. For a moment Hansun didn't understand what he was seeing.

'We've just opened fire,' announced the first officer dully.

'What?'

'Fucking Strivers,' someone said. *'Fucking Strivers must have worms in our network too. They couldn't leave their precious war to fate.'*

Orders flew back and forth. Hansun pulled up emergency guidance control, but his destruct commands didn't reach the torpedoes. The intruding ships diverged further, still not reacting, still not communicating.

'Hansun, shoot them down, unsafe the PDCs,' Ngoni ordered.

A number of the other ships were already attempting to do likewise, with mixed results as the torpedoes rapidly slipped beyond effective range, space filling with streams of kinetic rounds.

New orders from the Admiral arrived. They were to hold fire - projectile shots might be interpreted as further hostile action.

Everyone could see which way this was going.

'Battle stations,' the Captain ordered, the CIC lighting momentarily dipping as power was diverted to critical systems.

They could still avoid this, Hansun thought. If they could just get through to the intruders, they could make it clearer what was going on.

He pulled up the display. The torpedoes had already left the fleet far behind, accelerating hard towards the opposing ships. The PDC fire had stilled at last, but the clouds of rounds now also drifted inwards.

'Still no contact,' the first officer repeated. *'I think -'*

There was a harsh hiss of white noise over the comm.

'Jamming. They're jamming us.'

The screen shimmered, as grey 'invalid' icons appeared over half of the fleet's network links.

'It's starting,' said Hansun under his breath. The mic picked it up nevertheless. If this wasn't the point of no return, then they were close.

'Target lock them,' the Captain ordered, and new data blossomed in Hansun's tactical view, ranging and position data for the railgun. The LIDAR returns were weird, scattered and indistinct.

The intruding ships opened fire. One by one, so quickly that Hansun could scarcely believe what was happening, the torpedoes began to wink out. X-ray beams, the sensors said - powerful beyond belief, striking across tens of thousands of kilometres.

'Ten second warning. Prepare for combat manoeuvres. Synchronise with the fleet, full torpedo spread. Stow radiators. Railguns to automatic, PDCs to automatic.'

Crunch time. No matter that it was a mistake that had brought them here, this was combat, brutal and simple.

An alarm sounded and the *Isidore's* fusion drive stepped into high gear, flooding its plume with dense hydrocarbon slush. They dived towards the invaders at ten Gs, escorting unmanned corvettes accelerating harder and diverging. Even immersed in the gel the sudden force of it hit him like an avalanche.

The *Isidore* shuddered as torpedoes poured from her launch rails, drives lighting up space as they vanished from visual range in seconds. They were a mixture of kinetic buckshot and fusion devices, executing random evasion patterns as they rained inwards. Seconds stretched.

The torpedoes blinked out of existence, killed by perfectly aimed beams of hard radiation. The fleet kept firing nevertheless, spitting streams of torpedoes that vanished from sensor views, uselessly. It was like watching snow melt as it reaches the ground.

Torpedoes at long range, guns in close quarters - that was how things were supposed to go, and if they didn't get through, then you simply had to ramp up the fire rate. Except that wasn't going to work this time.

'Recommend reduce fire rate until close-quarters,' Hansun suggested. *'Long range torpedo strikes ineffective, suggesting modification of standard doctrine. Fire enough to occupy their laser weapons but don't waste torps. Lasers far outrange PDCs for missile defence, do not engage while they still have range advantage.'* Ngoni didn't respond.

Goddamnit, you're going to get us killed.

The military had continuously under-invested in laser tech - cheaper upfront to just fill the holds with more and more torps. Except it wasn't cheaper. This was the price. The warheads were finite.

The opposing ships stepped up their thrust, the three smaller craft curving to engage groups of Union ships, accelerating at rates that would surely kill any human onboard.

The attackers bounced and jerked from side-to-side with sudden lateral bursts of blue-white thruster fire, dodging the incoming buckshot as they approached the inner hemisphere of Union ships.

Hansun magnified the image of the intruder, watching as disturbingly organic, eyelid-like structures opened and closed along the ship's flanks, each one an emitter throwing out multiple independent beams of hard radiation.

The larger enemy ship lagged behind at a comparatively sedate five Gs. Soon they would be close enough, where the railguns and torps could begin to find their targets - so long as he still had sufficient ammunition to overwhelm their defences. Hansun was willing to bet that those almost delicate-looking pyramids couldn't withstand damage nearly as well as the solidly built Union vessels.

'Hold back our torpedoes,' came the order at last. *'Save for close range, give them less time to intercept. Work out improved guidance solutions - relay to weapons officers.'*

The torpedo fire ebbed. Still Hansun fretted.

Something's wrong, but what?

While Hansun worked through the streams of data with due diligence, frantically trying new torpedo control solutions for point-blank firing, the worry grew.

They aren't firing offensively.

The realisation came abruptly. The attackers had launched no torpedoes, no railgun rounds, nothing but defensive laser fire. Why?

Then the first of Union's destroyers exploded. Hansun felt a pang of fear and expanded the data stream, examining the ship's final relayed sensor logs - multiple hull breaches had registered milliseconds apart, as if the *Jayapal* had hit an invisible wall.

A ripple of destruction spread through the fleet, four, then six ships blowing apart into clouds of energised shrapnel with no apparent cause.

Don't panic. React.

Ngoni ordered a random evasion, and Hansun felt the drive stutter on and off. Another corvette exploded.

The ships had hit something, an object that had somehow remained invisible until the last moment. Stealthed railgun rounds? Cold mass ejection missiles? No, impossible - no stealth tech in existence was that effective at such a negligible range.

Their escort fleet was breaking apart - same for the other battlegroups, corvettes scattering in an attempt to avoid whatever-it-was. Hansun heard another officer curse under his breath.

In desperation Hansun pulled up the entire sensor log of the *Jayapal*, including non-tactical data, frantically searching for anything unusual.

Something caught his eye.

'They're using dusters,' he sent, along with an attached file, the secondary anti-collision sensors on the *Jayapal* registering a stream of incoming dust particles a tenth of a second before it died. *'Attackers' spinal mounts are hypervelocity micron-particle accelerators. They've been firing on us this entire time, but we didn't detect the projectiles - too small for radar.'*

He saw the Captain acknowledge the message, passing it on to the rest of the fleet. It didn't come quickly enough as another ship exploded, but then the sensor view reformatted as the radar switched to submillimeter waves, and suddenly the view ahead was filled with red streamers of approaching annihilation.

Collision alarms screamed and the *Isidore* performed a violent lateral jounce.

Hansun blacked out despite all the measures taken, coming to moments later. Other crew took longer to rouse, out of the loop for precious seconds, slowly coming back.

He'd always taken his high-G training seriously, earning a higher endurance score than anyone else aboard *Isidore*. He returned his gaze to the terminal, blinking to clear the spots in his vision, and drew in a ragged breath of the liquid air.

They'd avoided the dust cloud. Just. The detonations had ceased, but with more than twenty vessels disabled or destroyed.

Another wave of torpedoes, fewer than the first, died without reaching their targets. But they had bought time.

Soon the invaders would pass them and the field would briefly level. He had to prepare for those precious fleeting seconds to inflict maximum damage.

'Open fire with the main guns, keep them dodging,' the captain ordered.

Hansun fought against the rising fear, and designated the attacking ship with their main railgun batteries.

The guns fired, causing the lights in the CIC to dip briefly. The ship dodged, and dodged again, boxed in as the rounds hurtled by.

In response, the attackers' lasers turned on the *Isidore*, scoring gashes in their armour. They spun in a tight corkscrew, dissipating the laser energy across as much surface area as possible. Thermal alarms blared, but the hull held.

They were tough and could probably take more of a beating in close quarters. That had to be true. It was their only advantage.

Let's see them dodge PDC fire, Hansun thought. They were so close now - close enough that the rapid-fire kinetic cannons targeted the invader directly and opened up, spitting streams of rounds through the dwindling gap.

'Divert all reserves to the guns,' Ngoni ordered. *'Increase fire rate.'*

The display began to fill with new icons. At first Hansun assumed there was an error, some sensor malfunction or more viruses implanted by those twice-damned Strivers. The big ship had opened fire with torpedoes - no, not torpedoes.

Whatever they were, the projectiles were approaching at more than two hundred Gs. Then they accelerated still further.

Laser propelled missiles, Hansun thought, as the PDCs whirred, muzzles turning towards the rapidly approaching hostiles, trying to produce a viable flak cloud. The new contacts inched towards them on the display, and then began to disappear. Had they neutralised them?

The sensor view flickered, the CIC lighting shuddering as huge EMP effects washed over the fleet. The drones were working exactly as intended, releasing bright fingers of gamma radiation as their antimatter warheads detonated, killing the Union ships from far beyond PDC range.

Think of something clever…

Hansun's fogged mind searched through options, coming up blank.

More smart missiles reached their stand-off positions and expended themselves, while others broke apart into clouds of submunitions, kinetic impactors or specialized warheads that lit up their own, smaller antimatter drives as they diverged, spitting out brief, intense electron beams or jets of plasma. The enemy ships themselves came on, now almost unmolested amid the carnage their missile screen had unleashed.

This is too much, this can't be happening.

There were suddenly hundreds of fast-moving contacts approaching, half of them releasing their deadly payloads from far beyond point-defence range, mercilessly slicing through the screening corvettes.

Isidore jerked left and right, avoiding particle streams, counter-fire rising to strike the incessant swarm of warheads. The system threw up errors trying to catalogue the number of different weapon types; particle beams, electronic warfare, kinetic and explosive shots, fusion and antimatter…

Hansun's vision blurred again, more of the crew falling out of the comm loop as the oppressive acceleration rose and fell.

In desperation, some Union ships began targeting the smart missiles with railguns and their own torpedoes, despite dwindling reserves, leaving nothing for ship-to-ship combat. But the missiles had their own lasers, and when they met the torpedoes, most often they emerged unscathed. Some died to a torpedo strike or PDC hit, but it was too few, far too few.

Kinetic torpedoes had the most success, Hansun noted in a detached manner, especially if they were programmed to release their payload at a distance.

He sent commands to the launchers, reformatting their programming appropriately.

The bone-crushing thrust intensified. He tried to concentrate, but it was obvious which way this battle was going.

The sensor view began to break apart as x-ray beams, particle streams and the overwhelming bursts of antimatter warheads overloaded their instruments. Despite the chaos, fusion torpedoes finally began to find their targets, directed towards groups of the drones, scoring kills, but their nuclear explosions barely registered amid the energetic maelstrom.

Hansun didn't know how many ships were left, they were practically fighting blind. The ship jounced again and again, avoiding the approaching particle streams. The PDCs whirred, slugs tearing into submunitions and warheads that approached too close, but

their own ships continued to die in far greater numbers, to gamma beams and kinetic impacts that came on too fast to track, let alone intercept.

'Keep firing,' Ngoni ordered, as the destroyer and its escorts vectored about, scattering in a vain attempt to avoid incoming fire. *'Launch the torpedoes blind and set them to autoseek if you have to.'*

All the while the enemy spacecraft was closing, smashing its way through their escort cordon, dispatching *Isidore's* remaining corvettes with brief bursts from its lasers. This was their chance. Their last chance.

Captain Ngoni's orders came through, and she'd concluded the same.

The *Isidore* cut thrust as it flew through a cloud of energised plasma made by another dying Union ship. Wreckage thudded off the hull. Hansun felt his weight ebb to nothing, and almost blacked out again as the colossal drag of thrust lifted in a moment.

Soon, the enemy would pass within ten thousand kilometres, spitting distance in combat terms. With any luck, their sensor coverage would be weaker on their aft side, exposed as they sped past.

If fate favoured them, the attacker would think *Isidore* had been holed by a particle stream or cooked by one of the antimatter detonations and fly past without sparing them a second glance.

The ship approached, detectable through a haze of static, and Hansun saw the vector the Captain had plotted. They were to whip around, chasing the enemy from behind at an insane rate of acceleration, closing to railgun range on autopilot, and launching torpedoes from behind. But to neutralize such an enormous velocity differential, and loop back at them... Hansun saw the thrust estimates, redlining the drive and burning in low-impulse mode, melting the entire reaction chamber and nozzle in less than a minute. The *Isidore* might just survive, even if she'd never fly again, but there was no way the crew would make it.

'This is it,' Ngoni said simply. Somehow, at this last moment, Hansun felt nothing but calm.

'It's been a privilege, sir.'

Then there was no more time to think, just the enemy ship's icon passing theirs, a lateral shove as the *Isidores's* main drive spun them round and then what felt like a mountain fell on him as they accelerated towards the attacker at thirty Gs and opened fire with every remaining torpedo.

Hansun woke, his vision blurred by a red haze. He felt like he had been pushed through a meat grinder. Limb by limb, he carefully tested his body. He couldn't feel his right arm, or move it, and judging from how painful breathing was he had several broken ribs. Internal bleeding seemed likely.

He drew a ragged breath, coughing up a mixture of blood and the dregs of the acceleration mix.

The CIC, now drained, was eerily quiet, with debris floating everywhere, where displays and equipment had been ripped from their mountings. Even the alarms had stopped, and dim emergency lights were the only illumination besides the sporadic sparking of severed cables.

Hansun blinked again, trying to clear his vision. A bubble of blood swelled from his lips. He gingerly reached up to wipe it away, and then undid the straps on his couch, drifting into the CIC's central space.

'Hello?' Nobody answered.

'Ship, full system report.'

Nothing. But he wasn't breathing vacuum. If the ship was still in one piece, did that mean they had pulled it off?

Hansun pulled himself across the room, single-handed, clumsily dodging drifting hunks of machinery and bulkhead cladding.

'Captain…'

He looked around at the other crew in the CIC, seeing them for the first time. It wasn't a sight he was ever likely to forget.

'No…'

They lay, still enmeshed in their couches, heads tilted at impossible angles, eyes bloodshot. None were breathing. Captain Ngoni, her face surrounded by drifting droplets of blood, was among them.

Her skin was cold, and he couldn't feel a pulse. Her bloodshot eyes stared blindly back at him. Hansun looked away, fighting the urge to weep.

His tears welled up, briefly blinding him in the microgee. He wiped them away.

The Captain's display was still working. Hansun pulled it up, dismissing the pain and redness and nausea, trying to parse the blue and white graphics. He saw the Captain had already activated their emergency beacon, maybe her last act before death.

A stream of damage reports, too many to count, filled one panel - drive wrecked, ammunition spent, structural failure across the central axis, life support on battery backup, but at least the comm was working. Their distress call was still being broadcast. He turned to the tactical display.

The tag indicated it was not being updated live, but was the last valid inference the system had made from the ship's surviving instruments.

The Union fleet had scattered, the survivors running in disarray for the system's inhabited worlds or their fleet bases, throwing out chaff and jamming in a futile attempt to conceal their retreat. More than two thirds were destroyed, and the invaders...

Hansun wanted to scream with rage, but it came out as a feeble croak.

The invading ships had vectored right around and headed right back into the interstice like nothing had happened. But, he noticed, three ships were returning, not four.

Except for some badly healed nerves that largely manifested as a slight tremor in his right hand and the occasional brutal migraine, Hansun had made a good recovery, and earned a promotion, as well as a commendation for bravery. Other ships had recorded the *Isidore's* final stand. The images were plastered everywhere, on licenced and unlicenced feeds, displayed on graffiti prints and posters. They were milked for all they were worth.

It even pushed the expedition to the recently discovered interstice out of the headlines for a few days.

Hansun did not want to see the clips, the bright blue vector line making its hairpin turn, hull-camera views of the *Isidore* spitting torpedoes and PDC fire. The enemy ship, caught unawares, overwhelmed by the sudden ferocity of the attack, broken in half by projectiles and then, at last, consumed in the luminous white of a high-yield nuclear detonation.

A week passed, and the recriminations began. The initial attack had succeeded, and the *Atbarah* had blown a gaping hole through one of the habitats on the other side of the interstice. *'Perhaps two-hundred thousand have been killed, many of them irreversibly'.* Hansun found statements like that more than a little unnerving.

People lamented the terrorists' perversion of the ideals of Union, or suggested darkly that they were justified. Some blamed the radicals, others bought into the conspiracies about false flags and faked footage. The military was celebrated for its brave, upstanding defence of the system or slammed for its appalling corruption and incompetence.

Union's diplomats produced profuse apologies for the loss of life, and when it was announced a representative would be arriving from the other side, Lieutenant Hansun, survivor of the skirmish and decorated hero, discovered that he would be wheeled out to formally greet those who had killed them en masse. He didn't welcome the prospect, but his was not to reason why.

Hansun stood in the shuttle bay of the First Fleet anchorage, standing in his medical exoskeleton beside the imposing Admiral Aumonier as the shuttle approached; a simple, silver teardrop of memory-metal.

'They knew exactly what they were doing,' the Admiral murmured to Hansun, quietly enough that the other officers couldn't hear. 'I heard about what you did - spotting the duster guns. Smart move. Surely you also noticed that they jammed my comm request after the torpedo launch?'

Hansun nodded. The shuttle slowed to a halt, descending on violet pulses of thrust as it passed through the pressure curtain.

'I resent those conspiracy whacks as much as the next man, but they're onto something with this one. A single freighter on a suicide run, then a fleet waiting silently on the other side, somehow the *Atbarah* gets through, they jam us and start shooting - come on!'

'I…' Hansun trailed off. 'No sir, you're right, it doesn't make a lot of sense.'

'Tell you what does though. The one thing that's perfectly crystal-clear. Someone from our side killed a quarter million of their citizens. They don't care who did it. They don't care why they did it. What they care about is how it looks. It makes them look mortal. And because of that we needed to be taught a lesson, to have a few of our toys taken away, so that's exactly what they did.'

Hansun gulped, and turned away from the Admiral, towards the shuttle. It made an undeniable kind of sense, but -

Why did we launch the torpedoes?

There had been nothing - no investigation, no arrests, as if that particular mistake had never occurred. Without a second thought it had been entirely ruled out as a subject

worth the inquiry's time. Thousands dead after what was essentially an accident. But they already knew who to blame, so it didn't matter.

But it made Hansun wonder… if that was being covered up, what else was? Heads had rolled for the multiple security failures at Interstice Command. *If they were mere security failures*. Although it was usually safer to assume human error than conspiracy, he couldn't shake the suspicion that there must have been someone on the inside to do such damage. Someone with significant clearance.

'What's on your mind, Lieutenant?'

Something stopped Hansun from voicing his concern.

'Nothing sir, I'm honoured that you spoke frankly with me. I'm just as concerned about the implications of the incursion.'

'There's more, Lieutenant. Much more than I'm willing to let on right now, but you're going to find out for yourself soon enough,' explained the Admiral, as the ramp to the shuttle flowed open. 'I've received word from the science directorate, relating to the second interstice. Something big, potentially *shift-the-balance-of-power* big, has come up. And we'll be the ones to spring it on their negotiator. I want you to know, before we start, that they are not our friends. Do you understand, Lieutenant?'

'Yes, sir. I am well aware that they are not to be trusted.'

'Good,' Aumonier turned rigidly towards the shuttle, his voice taking on a solemn cadence. 'Don't forget, Lieutenant, that we are above all, the single unified voice of Humanity,' then, wryly, 'Or at least, we are when speaking to them.'

'Yes, sir.'

There was something wrong with the representative. He was shadowed by the open lip of the shuttlepod, but even so, Hansun could tell that he was oddly proportioned. They'd all heard the rumours about radical body-modification, but the reality was so much worse.

The figure was tall and hunched, its lithe forelimbs and powerful hindlimbs were broken looking, ending in manipulators that divided then divided again. It had a trilaterally symmetrical head with widely-spaced eyes of a pitiless, empty black. The lower half of the alien's face was obscured behind a sleek black electronic module.

This was a being that most Union citizens considered themselves lucky to have never encountered.

‘It’s -’ Hansun began, but Aumonier interrupted him.

‘She is an officer. I have heard of such, but they are rare. It was a deliberate gesture, sending their alien servant to meet us,’ said Aumonier. ‘Look sharp, Lieutenant.’

The creature was smaller than he expected and moved a little differently, more human-like, than he would have been led to believe. Its uniform was emblazoned with an angular bronze delta.

Two human officers followed the Dyn, dressed in similarly black uniforms adorned with no symbols of rank or allegiance other than that delta. The skin of their forearms and necks shimmered with inlaid patterns. Hansun thought the two humans had an arrogant cast to their faces, but perhaps he was only seeing what he wanted to see.

The representative walked up to them and bowed, its head almost coming level with Hansun’s.

‘I am Honed Aspect, commander of the battle sub-constellation which - regretfully - inflicted such heavy losses on your defence fleet.’ Its synthetic voice was feminine and sibilant, its affect utterly inscrutable. ‘On behalf of Arco, I extend my condolences.’

Eszel and the Listener - 2937

The foreign body arrived suddenly and without warning. The first the Whole knew, a thin sliver of heavy elements was emitting concentrated forms of energy, randomising many of the Whole's smaller elements. In itself this was tolerable. Intrusions occured, and could be allowed to pass by. However, this one was different. The Whole flipped its vision, like a man turning on a night vision scope. It saw the Structure, saw Mind. And now, the intruder shone with a terrible violet-black light. It burned. The Whole considered its next move. The Whole decided.

There had been such hope at first.

The sense of anticipation that surrounded the discovery of the second interstice is hard to overstate. For someone used to the grinding, glacial bureaucracy of Union, the inevitable manned mission to the wormhole in that distant system came together with surprising speed - from prototyping and planning, to assembly, training and departure in just twenty-eight frantic months.

Aumonier had been right - the discovery was a coup for us, in more ways than one. Even if it was only for a brief few years, the rising tides of recrimination, factionalism and militarism fanned by the Threshold Crisis subsided as we rediscovered our common purpose.

I’m not naive. I knew that there were baser motives at play. You don’t mobilise the vast resources required for interstellar travel purely out of a desire to seek out new frontiers or ennoble the human spirit.

Of course, I volunteered at the first opportunity - Aumonier had clearly expected it of me. But in my own way, I too came to believe in the mission.

So it was that I found myself on one of the twin vessels bound for the second interstice, almost twenty-six years ago.

We didn’t wait to retrieve more information from the vanguard probes. Even with our bleeding-edge drives it was deemed there was no time to waste on that faltering conversation with its decade-long pauses – besides, we could catch up en route. Instead, we plunged into the void with only tantalising precedent and our collective imaginations to suggest what we might find at our destination. Perhaps first contact with an alien civilisation? Or the reliquary of one long since extinct?

What we found was far more ambiguous.

We emerged from the interstice to find ourselves, as promised, in the trailing Lagrange point of one of the system’s handful of planets, a world we came to call Kailash. Older by far than Humanity's home, it had nevertheless narrowly failed to develop as an abundant cradle of life.

After billions of years as a cold, arid, Arean world, home only to prokaryotes, its sun's expansion had driven a surge in biocomplexity, the increased irradiance releasing life from its energetic constraints.

Kailash's thin atmosphere, radiation-scoured surface, sluggish geology and retreating seas meant that most complex organisms were confined to a maze of karst landscapes and sinkholes, like moss growing between the cracks of a badly-kept pavement. Life was forced to conserve, to cooperate, and in the end it learned to endure.

Yet somehow this only served to exaggerate the inescapable feeling of a world that was dying. Even the skies were a graveyard of red, a view from the fringes of a sterile elliptical galaxy. And while every interstice yet discovered led somewhere new and unknowably distant - galaxy cores, halo stars, the centres of globular clusters - to my mind no connection yet visited by human explorers was quite so frightening.

From almost the first instant of our arrival, I felt as if we were trespassing somewhere forbidden.

Still, we pressed on.

Now, in a geostationary orbit above Kailash, the *Invincible* hangs like a fixed star, watchful and wary. Of its sister vessel almost nothing remains but a thin cloud of wreckage. Dropships rise and dock with the ? at regular intervals, ferrying soldiers and material from the planet below, from the vicinity of a small and very recently formed crater north of the equator.

I am on the last dropship off Kailash. We depart in a couple of hours and the ? will leave this world behind not long after that, to begin the long journey home.

Kailash is not a world that welcomes our presence.

I looked down at the twisted piece of metal in my hands, turning it over restlessly.

Twenty-five years in stasis, only for the mission to fall apart within months, leaving more questions than it had answered.

'What a mess,' I said, to no-one in particular.

'Is that the official verdict of your team, Colonel Hansun?' asked Aumonier wryly, using my acting rank. I leapt at his voice, placing the shard back down and turning to face his virtual presence where it had appeared in the centre of the domed tent.

'Apologies sir, I wasn't expecting debriefing until I returned to the ?.'

'I think we're all just as keen to see the back of this place,' he said, waving my apology away. 'So, your initial assessment?'

The Admiral's holographic likeness squinted at me.

'To be honest sir, I don't… I've never seen anything like this,' I finished lamely. 'I don't think any of us have.'

I glanced back towards the crater rim, through insulating and airtight tent walls set to imitate transparency. My tremor was back, returning as it often did in moments of stress. I clamped my hand close to my leg, doing my best to still it.

Aumonier's projection stayed patiently silent while I tried to gather my thoughts.

The crater was all that remained where the base once stood, a cluster of extruded concrete shelters and prefabricated structures reduced to their constituent molecules.

I'd visited briefly whilst it was still being assembled, before returning to the ?, continuing our survey of the rest of the system.

Last manifest had put the base at almost two-hundred personnel, though accounting for all the bodies would be impossible.

Nothing recognisable remained. Oil

The entire base had somehow been transmuted into a thin slurry at the base of the crater, membrane-thick and almost perfectly lenticular, as if the entire complex, silicon, metal and carbon, had suddenly turned to liquid and flowed together. It looked like a poorly prepared microscope slide. Scattered around the crater were warped and twisted fragments of the structures that had been ejected, as if the base had simultaneously imploded and exploded.

'I'm no engineer, but none of this makes sense to me… the implied energy of whatever did this… ' I gestured helplessly.

Another dropship launched from the landing pad, kicking up clouds of dust before climbing on pillars of flame. I tracked its ascent, until my eyes wandered to where the light of the ? was just visible, up in geo-stationary beyond the blue-black zenith of the Kailash sky. Watching over us - for all the good it would do against something capable of this. After all, its sister vessel had been dispatched with similar ease.

Perhaps belatedly, I was seized by a very strong desire to not spend a moment longer here than necessary. If the mysterious annihilation struck again what could we do to defend against it? Our best hope was to be safely back on the other side of the interstice and unknowable light years away before it struck again.

'Anything else to add?' prompted Aumonier, as the roar from the dropship subsided. I just shook my head.

Aumonier nodded sympathetically.

'Well, the lab's analysed the samples your team collected, and it looks like what we would expect, chemically; mostly carbon allotropes, silicates, traces of biological matter. No indicators of any explosives however, nor an impactor.'

'Then what happened?'

'Best we've come up with so far is that a massive blunt object descended out of orbit and flattened it.'

'Is that a joke, sir?'

Aumonier let that statement hang in the air for a moment before continuing.

‘Some of the physicists ran simulations, and most of the effects we’ve seen could have resulted from the creation of a small region of extremely high gravity; hundreds of Gs at least, lasting perhaps a minute.’

I turned back to the wreckage, trying to imagine the scene. The base must have explosively relaxed when the gravity returned to normal. That would explain the deep crater and scattered debris.

‘Practical gravity manipulation,’ I mused. ‘Evidently not a natural disaster. So what’s the culprit? A failed experiment, perhaps? Someone messing with alien technology broke a few laws of physics?’

‘As far as we know, the Mimics have achieved energy densities required to work metal. Working the fabric of space-time would be considered a significant step up for them,’ chided Aumonier.

Still, the question remained… if the technology wasn’t the Mimics’, then whose?

‘That, and it seems the same fate befell the ? just days before,’ continued Aumonier, as though anticipating my next question. ‘We’d expect such a dramatic discovery to show up in their records. The base gave no indication of understanding what might have happened to the ? either. In fact, reports grow sporadic in the days leading up to the disaster – confused even.

But I suspect you’re right about something. There was intent behind this. Agency. And if not the Mimics themselves, then certainly a party unknown to us, with technology we don't understand.’

‘Do we have any theory as to how this might have been done?’

‘We spotted strange emissions from the sun immediately before both events. Abnormally large coronal mass ejections, radiation spikes. We didn’t make the connection until the second event - too much of a coincidence.’

The star’s trying to kill us.

I felt exposed, as though caught in the gaze of a malevolent eye, burning brightly overhead. We’re so far out of our depth. Why are we still here?

I held my tongue.

‘There are a few more specific theories; they might just have something really dense down there, monopoles or collapsed-state matter riding something like a vactrain line

under the planet. However, the consensus is that we're probably looking at post-desert physics.'

HDF legionnaires in bulky vacuum armour milled around the perimeter, shoulder-mounted burnpulsers unsafed and tracking for enemies that would never arrive, META rifles raised menacingly. Closer in, a wing of drones flew over the disaster site, low and fast, shimmering like a school of fish.

And there's the kicker. The logic of it all unfolded, and I glanced out at the ring of legionnaires and drones. There was one reason why they had risked a horrible death to come to this disaster site.

'And we have undisputed access to whatever produced this.'

Aumonier nodded approvingly.

'An extant culture with superior technology,' he said, his projection looking through me to something far away and indescribable. 'Humanity - our Union - has been fortunate in one way. Every other species we've encountered so far has been inferior, unsophisticated. What else could we learn, I wonder?

We're looking at a genuinely new piece of tech, something totally alien, generations ahead of anyone. And I do mean anyone. Even that bleeding-edge Arco conversion drive on the ? would be obsolete if we were able manipulate gravity in that fashion. Imagine if we'd had something like that at Threshold…'

'Yes, sir.'

'You doubt that this mission was worth it?' his tone sharpened, his gaze snapping back to me.

I had become a confidant for Aumonier, somebody he could speak to openly without concern for politics or propriety, but that gulf in seniority would always separate us. It was a friendship of sorts, but not one between equals.

I stared blankly at the wreckage and tried to marshal a response.

'No sir, the advantage this tech would give us is readily apparent,' I said carefully. 'But I would recommend caution. Just because we can see it doesn't mean we can duplicate it. We should still aim to minimise our time here… we're not prepared for something like this.'

A pair of silver drones spun in mid-air and darted up into the inky sky, then north, away from the crater. Something had them agitated. A priority alert flashed up in my peripheral vision.

'You are right, of course,' Aumonier conceded. 'We can't risk losing the ?. We've done what we can. Wrap up here and I'll see you -'

But I wasn't listening, distracted by a voice on the comms, muffled by interference. One of the recon drones had spotted something.

'I'll get a squad out there,' I confirmed.

'Hansun?'

I turned back to the Admiral.

'They found someone sir. A survivor.'

'Where?'

'That's the strange thing,' I said as I relayed the data on to him, and the footage; a suited human figure, wandering alone in the wastes, in grainy enhanced colour. 'They're almost eight-hundred and fifty kilometres from here. I'm taking a squad to retrieve them immediately. We'll need the last dropship. Can you send another to recover the final assets here?'

'I'll see that it's done. I'm sorry your departure will be delayed.'

'What's another few hours?' I asked, more cavalier than I felt. It had to be done. 'I'm not leaving someone behind. And if there's the slightest chance that we might be able to find out what happened we need to take it.'

Aumonier nodded, face solemn.

'You have your orders.'

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surprising speed - from prototyping and planning, to assembly, training and departure in just twenty-eight frantic months.

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But in my own way, I too came to believe in the mission. Of course, I volunteered at the first opportunity. Auomnier clearly expected it of me.

So it was, almost twenty-six years ago, that I found myself on one of the twin vessels bound for the second interstice.

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Our mission has failed.

I am on the last dropship off Kailash. We depart in a couple of hours and the ? will leave this world behind not long after that, to begin the long journey home.

Kailash is not a world that welcomes our presence.

'What a mess,' I said, to no-one in particular.

I looked down at the twisted piece of metal in my hands, letting the weight of it bend my wrist.

Twenty-five years in stasis, only for the mission to fall apart within months, leaving more questions than it had answered.

I couldn't even tell what part of the base the twisted metal had originally come from.

In some ways I wanted to reject what I was seeing, but I knew it was useless. You have to deal with the reality in front of you.

'Is that the official verdict of your team, Colonel Hansun?' asked Aumonier wryly, using my acting rank.

The Admiral's holographic presence squinted at me.

'No sir, sorry, I just… I've never seen anything like this,' I finished lamely. 'I don't think any of us have.'

I glanced back towards the crater rim. My tremor was back, returning as it often did in moments of stress.

Is he testing me?

I clamped my hand close to my leg, doing my best to still it.

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'I'm no engineer, but none of this makes sense to me… the implied energy of whatever did this… ' I gestured helplessly.

Another dropship came down behind us, settling onto the landing pad on pillars of flame, kicking up plumes of grey dust. Above, up in geo-stationary beyond the blue-black Kailash sky, the light of the ? was just visible, keeping watch - for all the good it would do against something capable of this. After all, its sister vessel had been dispatched seemingly in a moment.

Run. I was seized by the impulse to sprint for the dropship and flee. If the mysterious annihilation came again, it would be fast. I wouldn't even notice my death.

'So, your initial assessment, Hansun?' prompted Aumonier, once the roar from the dropship had subsided. I just shook my head.

Aumonier nodded sympathetically.

'Well, the lab's analysed the samples your team collected, and it looks like what we would expect, chemically; mostly carbon allotropes, silicates, traces of biological matter. This was the base, beyond any doubt.'

‘Then what happened?’

‘Best we’ve come up with so far is that a massive blunt object descended out of orbit and flattened it.’

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"Of course, sir."

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‘Belligerence? Do we have any theory as to how this might have been done?’

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I suddenly felt exposed, as though caught in the gaze of a malevolent eye, burning brightly overhead.

We're so far out of our depth. Why are we still here?

I held my tongue.

"We've thrown a few ideas around; they might just have something really dense down there, monopoles or collapsed-state matter riding something like a vactrain line under the planet. I wouldn't bet on it though; we're probably looking at post-desert physics."

HDF legionnaires in bulky vacuum armour milled around the perimeter, shoulder-mounted burnpulsers unsafed and tracking for enemies that would never arrive, META rifles raised menacingly. Closer in, a wing of drones flew over the disaster site, low and fast, shimmering like a school of fish.

And there's the kicker. The logic of it all unfolded, and I glanced out at the ring of legionnaires and drones. There was one reason why they had risked a horrible death to come to this disaster site.

"And we have undisputed access to whatever produced this."

Aumonier nodded approvingly.

"So you understand. We're looking at a genuinely new piece of tech, something totally alien and therefore not reproducible by anyone. And I do mean *anyone*. Those godforsaken Arco goons can't fly rings around us if we discover an authentic gravitonic drive. Imagine if we'd had something like that at Threshold."

"Yes, sir."

"You doubt that this is worth it?" his tone sharpened. "I sent you down to bring a fresh perspective. I hope my trust wasn't misplaced."

I looked at the collapsed pool of shredded matter, and tried to marshal a response.

"Sir, I would recommend caution. Just because we can see it doesn't mean we can duplicate it."

"A culture with superior technology, perhaps extant" Auomnier said, his projection looking behind the camera at something far away and indescribable. "Humanity - our Union, has been fortunate in one way. Every species we've encountered so far has been inferior, unsophisticated - the Dyn, the Tanu. What could we learn, I wonder?"

This is a mistake, I decided.

"I understand, sir. We should still aim to minimize our time on the surface."

I should minimize my time down here. You're safe in orbit. Safer, anyway.

"Yes, of course…" Auomnier trailed off.

Hansun turned around and noticed the Admiral wasn't listening, eyes darting elsewhere, consulting a display. I waited, raising my gaze to the inky sky. A pair of silver drones spun in midair and darted upwards, away from the crater. Something had them agitated.

The Admiral broke contact with the invisible screen and turned to me, face suddenly solemn.

"I'm afraid your survey will have to be cut short, Hansun."

A priority alert flashed up in my peripheral vision.

"I've called a flyer down to our location. You will need to board it and gather a legionnaire squad. Maximum readiness, unsafe everything. They'll explain on the way. Are my orders understood?"

"What's going on?"

When I saw the image I couldn't avoid yelling out of shock. There was a suited human figure in the frame, jumping up and down and waving its arms in the air in grainy enhanced colour. Then I saw the location data.

"They're almost fifteen hundred kilometers from-" I began.

"No. I don't want to hear about it, not just yet. Get over there and recover them, if at all possible. You have your orders."

Hansun's career had taken a storied path since his near-death at the hands of Arco three This decades ago. He'd been seconded to fleet intelligence after this discovery, given the rank of Colonel and transferred to the Kailash expedition.

He'd been submerged in coldsleep while the decades passed, thawed out and seen new worlds under alien skies and done his best to handle the complex logistics of establishing a forward base on an alien world. Then, in a moment, all their work had been wiped out, apparently by the boot of an angry god.

And somehow, I'm the point man once again.

Clearly, Aumonier had seen something in him. What it was, Hansun didn't quite understand. His staying power?

So here he was - trillions of kilometers from home as the distance could be conventionally measured, vastly further in reality, riding an ageing flyer on a suborbital hop across an alien world he barely understood, trying to salvage something from this disaster of a mission.

What could do something like that?

Hansun couldn't get the image of the liquefied base out of his mind - a view from a nightmare or a horror drama.

Perhaps it's my fate to be brought in to salvage fuckups, Hansun thought to himself as the flyer reached the top of its ballistic arc and began to descend. Perhaps the survivor would shed some light on what had happened.

But that just leads to further questions - how did they make it so far alone?

Somehow Hansun knew that this wasn't all going to unravel neatly.

And all the while, the invisible death waited. If Aumonier had been right, and the hidden machinery could play with the inner structure of space-time, manipulating gravity with ease and finesse, he wasn't safe even now. The ? In orbit wasn't safe either.

Would there be a sign? Would I feel my body being torn apart before the end?

The Legionaries around him sat stiffly in their heavy armour as their air brakes deployed and the thrusters kicked in, the thin atmosphere of Kailash turning from blue-black to merely deep blue - even at ground level the air was too thin to breathe without assistance. There was a thud as the flyer made contact with the ground, another as the ramp descended, and the squad filed out after Hansun.

They were near the equator, on a relatively high plateau - piles of erratic boulders littered the landscape, relics of ancient glacial flows. The grey dirt crunched beneath Hansun's feet as he advanced, the legionnaires' targeting lasers skating over the landscape of low hills.

Hansun clutched his own pistol, holding it low - just in case. There were enough unknowns here that he wouldn't go in without precautions.

He could see the survivor just ahead, sitting cross-legged on the dirt.

It's small. A child?

"Point those somewhere else, I don't want anyone getting tagged," Hansun snapped. The heavy ballistic rifles shifted, targeting beams aimed down.

The survivor was quite close now, facing away from them. He could already tell they were thin, maybe starved.

Hansun raised his hand and the squad halted.

"For god's sake, we're not here to arrest them. Hold position, linkup with my suit cam. I'll go on ahead."

Hansun turned on his suit speakers as he walked forward,

"We're from the expedition," his voice echoed. "Are you alright?"

The figure turned towards him. Hansun realized with a start that she was just a girl - about eighteen, skinny, with a narrow face and unkempt dark hair, wearing one of the standard-issue exo-environment suits and a transparent mask. It was patched and stitched up in places, covered in grime and dirt.

A couple of seconds later facial recognition kicked in - Eszel, family of the former base's civilian crew, reported missing five weeks ago.

Five weeks?

Hansun tried to give a reassuring smile, aware of how intimidating he must appear, backed by the line of towering legionnaires. He pointed his gun at the ground.

"You're safe now," he said.

The girl met his eyes, face blank. The moment seemed to stretch, tension building in a way that Hansun couldn't quite identify. She didn't move, didn't say anything.

"You're safe," he repeated.

The girl burst into tears.

"I thought I was dead," she sniffed, voice muffled by her suit respirator. "I didn't think I'd ever…" she trailed off.

"It's alright," said Hansun, motioning for the legionaries to move forward. "We're evacuating the planet, you need to come with us."

Eszel hesitated for a moment, casting an apprehensive eye at Hansun. Then she smiled and reached out to take Hansun's hand.

"Can you walk to the lander?" he asked, trying to soften his voice. The girl nodded.

They didn't stay in orbit a second longer than necessary. In the end, a small surface camera was the only thing left to mark the fate of the base's wreckage. Perfectly controlled lines of plasma arrowed down from the sky, glowing even in the thin local air. Light bloomed and spread, shock waves shredding the wreckage of the base and the human detritus left behind by the recovery crews.

1

I'd been left alone in the small room - a room that they still insisted was not a jail cell.

I lay slouched over the hard foammetal table, playing idly with a strand of my hair, not looking up.

The metal felt cold on my skin, uncomfortably so, but I didn't sit up. Project an image, Essie - lie with every gesture and action.

If I was going to make it through this, I had to play everything just right.

There was nothing in the definitely-not-a-cell other than a table and two uncomfortable chairs, but I could still hear a chittering emanating from the walls, a vaguely electronic noise that indicated circulating currents and the ebbing and flowing of magnetic fields. I'd wracked my brains trying to think what it might be, maybe unshielded electrics, and concluded that it must be microM or QES tech, scanning my brain for truthfulness.

Still, I didn't look up. A few minutes passed.

Did they expect me to be more forthcoming if I'd been left here with my own thoughts for just a few minutes? If so, then they'd underestimated me - again.

Minutes more passed, and I wondered how long they were legally permitted to keep me waiting. I'd have to look that up after this was over.

There was no reason to be afraid. There was nothing to be afraid of. Remember that.

He wouldn't hint of fear or uncertainty from me. Not now, no matter what. They were all in the wrong, and what was worse was that they knew it.

I'd give them boredom and mild irritation, and they could conclude whatever they wanted.

The wait continued.

I could feel the slight vibration of the drive through the desk, minute fluctuations in thrust that made the entire room hum subliminally. It gave everything a slightly fuzzy quality, as if I needed visual corrective surgery. Even that felt like it was a tactic, somehow, like this had all been arranged simply to make my life as uncomfortable as possible.

They aren't here to help you, remember that. They're here to catch you out.

The door opened, and the bulky shape of Colonel Hansun stepped inside, his fleet uniform immaculately pressed.

The colonel had clearly been an athletic man at one point, with a mixture of african and asiatic features that marked him oht as a native of Deliverage, but he was showing signs of age - balding, with a distracted air and a tremor along one arm.

As the colonel sat, I noticed the way he positioned himself at a slight angle, attempting to de-emphasise that side of his body. Insecure.

Remember that - it might be important later. Anything might be important.

Hansun gave a slightly apologetic nod and a murmured word of greeting, which I didn't return.

I didn't meet his eyes, letting the moment stretch. Hansun coughed. I waited.

A few more seconds passed. Almost there.

I sat suddenly, putting on a placid smile, which only widened upon seeing his reaction. The colonel straightened his navy uniform and tilted his head up a little.

"I'm sorry to have kept you waiting, Essie."

"Eszel. My friends called me Essie."

I was not being interrogated; the navy troopers had been very clear about that, several times.

"Yes, of course," the colonel nodded slowly. "Let me say again just how sorry I am, Eszel. We understand what you're going through, and if there's anything we can-"

"No you don't understand," I snapped, putting just the right amount of hurt into the words.

The colonel gave me a stony look, and I wondered if I'd pushed it too far.

I was a traumatized girl, the only survivor of a catastrophe, I needed rest and to have my story listened to.

It was hard to keep an even temper through it all, but somehow I'd managed so far. More or less. I'd certainly made a good try of it.

"Is there anything you'd like? Something to drink-"

"Let's just start, Colonel."

"Hansun, please. I'm not here in any military capacity."

So I'm not the only one lying today… too bad you're no good at it, Colonel.

"Very well, if you're sure. Why don't we start at the beginning?" Hansun made a subliminal twitch with one hand, and I knew he'd activated some type of recording device.

"Which beginning?"

"Whenever you'd like. I want to know how you ended up here, in your own words. Any details might be important."

"From when I left the base or…"

"From your first involvement with the mission."

Ah, so that's your game. Get me to talk as much as possible, in as much detail as possible, to try and catch me in a lie. Clever.

"You want to know everything? We'll be here for years."

"I meant everything relevant, Eszel. Why don't you start with how you found out about the expedition?"

"Fine."

Essie lay sideways on her bed with the broad picture window in front of the balcony de-opaqued, revealing a square of sky with only a few of the taller skyscrapers visible. She liked to watch the ships rising in the night. They wafted up like little flecks of ash,

shimmering as they caught the light of the launch beams. She focussed on one, and though it wasn't visible as anything more than a speck at this distance, the delicate geometry was clear by the way the exhaust jet billowed out behind it - the ice-sheathed parabolic reflector that bounced the laser light and the way the air flowed around it, dividing the smooth flow like a scissor slicing through fabric.

Her slate said the design was five hundred years old, based on technology approved by the Threshold Authority for zero-tariff sale everywhere in the Union, and so it had been ubiquitous for almost as long as the Union had existed. She could have stood on this same balcony and seen this same sight two hundred years ago. Maybe she'd come back in two hundred years and watch the same thing again.

"It's twenty years!" said an older female voice, audible even through her room's walls. "We can't just uproot her like this!"

"Most people would give their lives for what I've given us - do you have any idea how long the lottery list was, how lucky we were to be selected!" a deeper voice, male.

"Oh yes, the lottery. The lottery that you entered without even thinking about how it would affect me or Essie… without even asking us!"

"This was a chance I had to take. It'll be historic, a chance we can't ever-"

"You don't know what you're missing right here!" the female voice grew louder.

The firefly light winked out. Essie knew what that meant - the shuttle had completed its launch, flung out so fast that the world curved beneath it faster than it could fall.

On impulse, she said a few words to her bedroom's system and called up Newton's ancient diagram that explained orbits, throwing the image onto the wall. She looked at it, a thousand years old and still as true as the day it had been drawn.

She'd always found it funny - some things, the holos in her room, the clouds, would change from day to day or minute to minute. Some things lasted for lifetimes, like the design of those launchers. But other things couldn't change, not ever.

In the background, the argument continued, the female voice full of concern and worry, the male strident and indignant. The roles continue to play out, action and reaction. Boring, predictable, simple.

She tried to blot out the sounds of their argument. It was easy, really.

If you made them no longer a part of your personal universe, they couldn't bother you.

And it was predictable - *she* secretly wanted to say yes to the mission as much as *he* did, but felt she had to stage a guilt fit first because of how it would impact her family, *he* felt bad about not asking her first, and did his best to cover it up with bluster. Pretending, always pretending, everyone always pretending and lying and lying. It drove Essie mad. Maybe things wouldn't be the same at the new star. Then again, they probably would.

The way people acted had always made her angry, in an oblique way that'd she'd never been good at expressing. She knew they couldn't help it, but somehow that just made it worse.

Essie stood up from her chair and threw the balcony window open, stepping out onto the marble and placing both her hands on the railings. She hoisted herself up on both arms, feeling her feet leave the ground and her elbows lock. She leant over the balcony, tipping forward almost to the point where she'd overbalance, and holding there, swaying gently. The breeze rustled her hair, and she tilted her head up a bit. If she could just forget about her arms holding herself up, it was almost like she was flying, like the time when she'd been very small and her class had taken a day trip to one of the sky-bubbles.

Essie looked down, past the lip of the balcony, down the dozens of stories of the skyscraper to ground level, and tipped forward a little further, feeling slightly giddy. She felt her heart race, but there wasn't anything else there, nothing like fear, just exhilaration at being so close to something new and exciting, even if that new thing was death.

She could keep tipping forwards, and if she kept it up maybe she'd lose her nerve and fall eventually. Maybe falling that far would scare her. Or maybe it wouldn't.

2

The news of the anomaly had arrived in increments, trickling back across lightyears from a nameless system so overlooked it had apparently never merited more than a catalogue designation. Probes had been this way before, but never lingered, hurtling by at a mere order of mag below c, gathering only enough data to broadly confirm what we already knew. A DZ class white dwarf. A halo of debris and frozen planetesimals. *Nothing more to see here*.

It had been hundreds of years before somebody had bothered to send a follow up - one of the vast development combines seeking to stake a claim on the off chance that at some point, another few centuries hence, it might become economical to exploit the system.

The discovery was a fluke - as the surveying probe made its protracted deceleration, magsail unfurled, it caught a glimpse of something in its scopes. Something that appeared to warp the stars behind it, the emission spectra and mass profile utterly wrong for an object that could not be much more than a kilometre across. Driven by an ersatz mechanical curiosity, the probe altered it's approach, swinging towards the star then out into a wide ellipse that would take it back to the anomaly's distant orbit.

I can only imagine the impatience those privy to the initial discovery must have felt as they waited long months for the probe to reacquire its newfound target, made all the more agonising given the knowledge that this was already old news, the data already a decade out of date. But as it drew closer they were able to ascertain that which they had already tentatively begun to suspect. A second interstice, right there in the heart of Union space. A stabilised, macro-scale wormhole leading to god-knows-where, barely a stone's throw away in interstellar terms.

The news leaked soon afterwards - not even a corp could keep a secret like that, not when they'd just blundered across it. Of course they extracted concessions and contracts as restitution but within hours it was out of their hands and under government aegis.

Even with our bleeding-edge conversion drives we weren't risking being beaten to the punch.

It had all began before Eszel had been born, when a routine sky survey from a world on the fringe of the Union-controlled segment of the great interstice network had identified a planet, close in conventional interstellar terms, with an oxygen atmosphere, which orbited an unstable elderly red-giant star. A new biosphere was a rarity, with only a few dozen examples yet directly sampled, and this deserved closer study.

The Byzantine structures in the Union bureaucracy came up with the name Kailash. Funding was secured and an interstellar-capable Star Archer was constructed and deployed a dozen light-sail probes, accelerating each to a substantial fraction of lightspeed. It was when the first of these probes clipped by the world, Kailash, that attention truly exploded. There were thermal emissions, lights on the surface, signs of technological civilization.

The Union senate saw their chance – the Xianists had the Tanu, Arco had the Dyn – this was their opportunity to gain access to an intelligent, and above all technological culture.

After negotiation with Arco, made easier by their recent transgressions into Union space, an interstellar-capable propulsion unit was leased, in exchange for promises that it would be used for peaceful exploration only.

Humanity had taken centuries to bridge the energy desert - the vast gulf that separated the electroweak energies that even 21st century technology could probe, and the grand unified realm where matter and force flowed into new, stranger forms.

Arco's barely-controlled Armstrong accelerator tests in deep space and later the more stable monopole condensers, had finally achieved that long sought after goal, and opening up a new realm of fundamental physics. One result, the vacuum energy drive, was unstable and poorly understood, but capable of sucking energy from an apparently limitless well.

The hull of the HDFS Invincible was constructed around the Arco-built propulsion unit and augmented to transport a crew of several hundred sleepers at a substantial fraction of c. For the expected twenty-one-year round trip, ten years out and a year on site, and ten years to return, limited allowance was made for civilian families.

Hansun leaned forward, his elbows resting on the cold metal table. The harsh lighting of the interrogation room cast deep shadows across his face, accentuating the lines of worry that had formed over the past few weeks.

"Your parents brought you along with them. Were you excited, scared?"

Eszel met his gaze, her expression carefully neutral. "I was six years old, aAnd I'd been told I was going to fly to a planet around another star. So yes, I was excited."

She analysed his body language, the slight tilt of his head, the way his fingers tapped almost imperceptibly on the table. He's trying to establish a rapport.

Hansun smiled, a gesture that didn't quite reach his eyes. "I'd have been excited by that too. I was, in fact, and I was already a seasoned officer when I first heard about Kailash."

She nodded, and a moment passed.

Undeterred, Hansun pressed on. "Alien life, what is this, only the sixth ever independent discovery of intelligence. Was it something you found particularly interesting as you got older?"

"Sure, I guess. Who wouldn't be interested in aliens?"

"Can you elaborate on that?" Hansun asked, leaning in slightly. "What aspects of the Kailash fascinated you the most?"

Eszel paused, considering her response carefully. "Their biology, I suppose," she said finally. "The way they adapted to such an inhospitable environment. It's... admirable."

Hansun nodded, making a note on his datapad. "And what about their technology? We found some truly remarkable things on Kailash."

"Like what?" Eszel asked, allowing a hint of curiosity to color her voice.

"Well," Hansun began, "their manipulation of gravity, for one. We barely understood the principles, but the applications were... astounding."

Eszel felt a thrill run through her, remembering the glimpses she'd seen of the Kailash technology. "Astounding," she echoed, her voice distant. "Yes, I suppose it was."

Hansun's eyes narrowed slightly at her tone. "You sound like you gave it a lot of attention," he probed.

Oh whoops. Probably shouldn't have said that.

"I peruse the reports we got at the base," she said, forcing a shrug. "Before... you know."

"Right," Hansun said, his voice heavy with unspoken questions. "About the base. When you were there, did you notice anything unusual? Anything that might have hinted at what was to come?"

“Unusual how?" she asked.

"Strange phenomena, unexplained events, anything out of the ordinary," Hansun pressed.

A flicker of fear crossed her face. "There were... tremors sometimes. And lights in the sky that didn't match any known celestial bodies. But the scientists said it was just normal planetary activity."

Hansun leaned back, his expression unreadable. "And you believed them?"

"Why wouldn't I?" Eszel countered, a edge of defiance in her voice. "I was just a kid."

"A very intelligent kid," Hansun observed. "Your academic records are impressive. You had a particular aptitude for physics, I noticed."

Eszel felt a surge of pride, quickly suppressed. "So what? Lots of kids are good at science."

"Not many understand quantum field theory at sixteen," Hansun said mildly. “And political philosophy: I heard you gave your teacher quite a headache about posthumanism. And, cell biology, and… well everything. You have a bright future ahead of you.”

Eszel remained silent, sensing a trap.

Hansun changed tack. "Let's go back to the Kailash themselves. Did you ever interact with them directly?"

"No," Eszel lied smoothly. "They kept us kids away from the contact zones."

"But you must have been curious," Hansun pressed. "A brilliant young mind like yours, faced with an advanced alien civilization. Didn't you ever try to... bend the rules a little?"

Eszel allowed a smirk to play across her lips. "Maybe," she said,. "What would you have done?"

Hansun chuckled, but there was no humor in it. "I'm not the one being questioned here, Eszel."

"Aren't I?" Eszel shot back. "Feels an awful lot like an interrogation to me."

"It's not," Hansun said firmly. "We're just trying to understand what happened. You're the only survivor, Eszel. Your perspective is invaluable."

Eszel felt a flicker of something – not quite guilt, but a shadow of what guilt might feel like in someone else. "I've told you everything I know," she said, her voice suddenly tired.

Hansun studied her for a long moment. "Have you?" he asked softly.

She met Hansun's gaze and said, with perfect sincerity, "Yes. I have."

The common room was crowded when Eszel arrived, and she couldn’t help but notice the instant dip in the volume of conversation. Lao and Noah turned towards her, Noah showing something colourful on his terminal display.

"Hey," she said.

Eszel leaned in closer, glancing over the image, part of an art project he'd been working on for class.

"What do you think?" asked the older boy. Eszel frowned. It was colourful, like a collection of burnished metal wires strung together. “Nice, right?”

"Pretty good… But then I don't know art."

Noah smirked. Eszel frowned.

"Let me guess… the terminal did it for you."

“Nobody’s ever gonna know, so who cares?”

Eszel pursed her lips in mock condemnation. Noah laughed as they all headed out the door on the chime.

The rooms of the Invincible were burnished grey nanotube weave, as light and simple a design as possible.

They all filed into the tutorial room, Eszel bringing up the rear and taking a seat next to Noah.

The room’s lights darkened as the presentation began.

There hadn’t been room for educators on the flight, so the Union had - despite its usual aversion to such things - resorted to virtual personas. She suspected that he was designed for significantly younger children.

Eszel spread her slate out on the table and planted an expression on her face, feigning attention. She’d always been good at that.

Jonathan winked into existence in the volumetric display - he looked professionally put together, like a newsfeed anchor, but his voice was slightly off, with a patronising edge to it that Eszel always found grating.

“I’m so glad to see everyone here. It’s time to continue with yesterday’s lecture. But first, our weekly journey update!” A stylised map of the interstice network appeared, showing the multiple connections they’d hopped between to reach the outpost, and the huge real-space distance they had crossed since.

Eszel did her best to look like she was paying attention as the volumetric display zoomed out, showing the arrow-straight trajectory of the Invincible, just about a twentieth of the way to Kailash.

“We are moving at almost half of the speed of light - that’s fast enough to cross from one end of Stellenar to the other more than three times in a single second. Just think about that!” Jonathan continued. “We have three weeks left until we all go under for the long sleep to face the unknown. Who’s excited for that?”

There was muttered assent. Not for the first time, Eszel wished she could actually see the space outside Invincible, instead of being shuffled around like cargo from one world to another.

“With that out of the way, it’s time for the rest of today’s lesson. Who remembers our topic?”

There was silence for a moment.

“Citizenship and history,” said Noah, dully.

“That’s right!” Jonathan beamed. “We’ll cover an overview first, just to ensure everyone’s caught up.”

The view shifted and Union’s flag, the stylized Vitruvian man on a field of blue, appeared behind Jonathan.

“General background. The Unified Government of Humanity has been in existence for more than five hundred years. That’s longer than almost all the governments of old Earth, before the Arco conquered and subjugated it. Although we can trace our founding back to the old United Nations of Earth, our true origin is generally agreed to be… when?”

“The settlement act?” said someone.

“Not quite - that’s when our constitution was written, but it wasn’t when we truly began. Anyone else?”

Nobody answered. Eszel knew this one - she’d always enjoyed historical stories, tales of struggle against desperate odds, and a part of her had always wished she’d lived in those times, as horrible as they’d been. She said nothing.

“The aftermath of the Dyn invasion, the exodus fleet,” said someone near the front.

“Correct,” Jonathan nodded. “I’m glad to see that some of you have done your research. I know that this is a busy time for us all, but your schooling is very important. Like many of the other polities currently making up human space, we can trace our origin-”

It was quite incredible, Eszel thought, the way the desk jockeys who planned this mission had managed to make a bold adventure to find life around another star this boring.

The question-and-answer session continued for a time.

“-you know our official name - the Unified Government of Humanity. But you've met Arcosians and Xianists - they're human. So why are we the government of all humanity?"

Silence. Don't say anything, Essie. It's not worth it.

"It's a lie, that's why."

A few people turned to look at her. Eszel kept a flat expression.

“Don’t look for sense in a name like that, it’s just propaganda.”

Jonathan flickered for a second. He wasn’t quite Turing-level, let alone generally intelligent, and her question might have tested some parameter. She’d sometimes wondered if it was possible to push him way outside his training distribution with the right combination of questions, and make his entire program break down.

“Eszel has just asked a very good question,” said Jonathan. “Who can tell me what propaganda is?”

Nobody answered.

Noah elbowed her in the ribs. She shook her head.

“It’s when you say something to make people believe you, even if you’re lying,” said Noah.

“Good. So who can answer Eszel’s question? What’s the real reason we are called the ‘Unified Government of humanity’?”

Silence.

“Very well. Our Union is not the only government containing humans, but it is a government of humanity, by humanity and for humanity - and that truly is unique, and worth protecting. It's why we have the threshold committee. Who can tell me what the threshold-”

Eszel’s thoughts turned to the world outside. Every week, Jonathan showed their weekly progress review, and they watched that tiny icon inch further away from the outpost system.

They never got a decent look outside, at the way their sheer velocity would distort the light around them, and the sheer gulf of space between them and the nearest world or star.

She pulled up a diagram of the ship on her slate. Jonathan was still speaking,

“The Threshold itself - it is the original interstice discovered by our founders, which led to our own, closely-connected portion of the network.”

A graphic appeared behind Jonathan, a map showing marked stars, and a half-dozen small icosahedrons, symbols that represented trans-spatial connections, scattered almost randomly in a region centred on a single star.

“Who can tell me the name of that star?” said Jonathan.

“It’s Earth’s star, isn’t it? Sol,” said someone.

“Correct,” Jonathan beamed. “Sadly, Earth has been under occupation by Arco for many hundreds of years now. Part of learning and growing up is coming to understand that the world is not always nice, and that there are people out there who are dangerous.”

Eszel rolled her eyes. This was about as subtle as a chisel. She had to get away from it.

“But sometimes fate is kind to us - if we had not found the Threshold, our exodus might never have survived in the first place, and then Arco would have ruled everyone. So you see, there is always something to be grateful for!”

Jonathan nodded enthusiastically, and the view on the volumetric display behind him zoomed out, beyond the tiny bubble of stars around Earth, switching between views of different stars.

“To this day, our scientists don’t know how common network interstices really are, or how far apart the stars they link together are in the real universe. All we know is that we can find some around the stars near Sol, and that almost every star they link to have their own scattering of connections. Sometimes, we are lucky, and they are strung very close together, with short gaps between. Sometimes two orbit the same planet! Often the gaps are much bigger, and we need huge ships like our own to travel between them.”

She had to get away from it.

Eszel frowned. Where had that thought of escape come from? It was a weird feeling, as if the impulse had suddenly struck her like a lightning bolt. But at that moment the desire to escape from the monotony of ship life was so strong it was almost unbearable.

Jonathan continued to drone on, explaining things she already knew.

“We once thought those interstices might be wormholes, but now are less sure exactly what they are... the term ‘trans-spatial connection’ is a sort of placeholder, really. One, long ago, led all the way to the Dyn’s ancient empire. Another was our own Threshold star, and still another, through many links in the chain that begun at the Threshold, and led through our home, Stellenar, led to the outpost that our own expedition launched from-”

Eszel was engrossed in the ship's diagram. True to form, there weren't windows anywhere in the habitation section. If she wanted to stargaze, that wasn't an option.

Just go outside and look.

Eszel sighed to herself. The thought was somehow halfway between a voice and mere instinct, like it was just on the edge of forming true words. She knew it was pointless to argue with herself.

The three of them sat around a table in the common room.

"You want to climb your way into the outer hull?" said Lao.

"Shh, not so loud," Eszel nodded. "We're not going to go anywhere dangerous, nowhere near the engines or anything. There's a passage the service bots use, to reach the spine elevators. We don't need to go hardly anywhere," she flicked her finger over the terminal, magnifying part of the schematic.

The Invincible was built with the habitat section in the middle of a long pylon, a plasma umbrella projected to the fore and the propulsor held to the aft. Eszel magnified one of the access elevators.

"We just need to screw up the sensors for five minutes, move the elevator just far enough to be out from underneath the hab module, and then we'll see it - nothing but open space for ten billion light years to either side!"

"Essie, we can't. It's too dangerous."

"It's not," she snapped. "And don't call me that. They just don't want us down there because it's off limits. They probably didn't think any of it through, just the usual - don't go there because we said so."

"But, what's the point? Just to say we've done it?"

Eszel rolled her eyes. The next words came easily.

"You're going to go through life like that, aren't you? If the only reason you don't do something is that it doesn't pass some kind of complicated cost benefit test about whether it's worth it… then what's the point in living?"

Lao still looked uncomfortable.

"So the point is that there is no point?"

Oh, you did not just say that.

“You want to be a fucking slave to the fleet, to your parents? Think for yourself for once, Lao.”

He just needed a little nudge, and then it would be a done deal.

Eszel glanced over at Noah.

“I like the idea,” he said, in a tone that indicated he didn’t. Eszel beamed, and the two of them looked back at Lao.

“We can take a terminal and record the whole thing, and keep hold of it for the rest of the trip. It’ll be our secret, and then when we’re back home, and they can’t come after us to enforce their rules, release it on the streams…” she said, eyes darting from Lao to Noah.

Lao nodded slowly, as if he couldn’t believe the words coming out of his own mouth.

“Okay. I’ll get one of those disposable terminals, so they don’t find the file.”

“Great, it’s settled. Meet me at this junction at 2000 hours. I’ll work up a hack for the internal sensors.”

Eszel raced through the rest of the day - mandatory exercise in the gym, another round of lessons, a quick dinner with her parents in their cabin, an ancient rerun of an Oskar Nozoka neo-thriller on their display portal, half an hour for them both to fall asleep, then up and out as silently as possible.

The sensor hack on her terminal worked perfectly, and none of the second shift workers spared her a glance as she made her way spinward to the elevator terminal. Project confidence, and you can get away with a lot - she’d lived by that maxim for much of her life, and it had rarely failed.

Eszel stepped into the access passage and walked along the rarely-trodden path, stooping a little as she moved. Lao and Noah were already waiting for her, facing away.

“Boo.”

The two of them jumped whipped around, a shadow of a scowl crossing Lao’s face. Eszel smiled innocently and stepped towards the door.

“All ready to go?”

“Sure.”

“I guess.”

She touched her terminal to the elevator, activating the hack she’d worked up. There was a brief interval while the override went to work, and then the door slid open. The two boys followed her inside reluctantly, and then the door slid shut, isolating them from the ship. There were a pair of wide cupola windows to either side, currently showing the inside of the elevator.

“Just five minutes, right?” said Lao. “We’re just going to look around, take a video, then-”

“That’s what we said, right?” said Noah.

Eszel ignored them both, working at her terminal, negotiating past the simple security system. There was a slight lurch beneath them as the elevator dipped, and they began to descend. Lao and Noah exchanged a few words, but Eszel stayed silent.

You’re close now.

The intruding thought was more word-like, this time, almost as if someone behind her had spoken. She felt an impulse and turned, but it was just Lao and Noah.

Lao looked worried, but he was still holding up the terminal, panning the device around to capture the entire view. Noah was worried as well, but he was doing a better job of hiding it. She smiled at them both, and then, quite suddenly, the light coming through the windows shifted.

Eszel and the boys turned to the windows, and they saw the space between stars.

“Woah,” said someone behind her. Eszel wasn’t sure who. The two of them moved around the other window, somehow knowing not to bother her.

None of the stars were familiar, of course. This was not the even the same galaxy she’d been born within. Nobody had ever mapped the links between two nodes in the network.

Her mind kept trying to find and match constellations, patterns she knew, but there was genuinely nothing familiar, just brilliant cold light and endless space.

At this velocity, the starlight was bent - only subtly, but there was a tendency for stars to collect above and below, as if they were headed towards a great cluster of bluish stars, fleeing from a cluster of old, red stars. They weren’t - it was just a trick of aberration.

And framing it all, the central pylon of the Invincible - to the front, a globe of dull metal, illuminated by running lights, and to the aft, an obscured pillar of luminous blue, surrounded by the wide disc that was the drive unit viewed from directly. She felt giddy,

and her gaze was drawn back to the stars. There was something captivating and strange about the view, something beyond the obvious.

The empty space between the stars seemed to shimmer, like the darkness behind closed eyelids, colours that weren't quite colours drifting in and out, just on the edge of perception.

She felt was another wave of dizziness, more obviously perceptible, and a flash of light from below. Eszel flinched back, but something compelled her to keep looking into the shadow between the stars, and she leant forwards again. The giddiness returned, stronger this time, and something else - a taste like metal.

Why did I call it a shadow?

What am I calling 'it'?

There was nothing fearful there, nothing dangerous about the blackness, just something illusive, fascinating. She felt like she could have stood there for hours.

"Why did I never see it before…" she wondered.

There was a thud from behind Eszel, snapping her out of her reverie. She whipped around, and saw Noah, holding Lao, doubled over, retching.

She felt sick too, and threw out an arm to steady herself.

"The drive," Noah moaned. Eszel nodded, doubling over again, a retch rising to her own mouth. She suppressed it. Lao swayed.

You know what this is.

"Lie down, both of you, now." they obeyed. At least now they won't fall and hurt yourselves.

Don't think about it, just get away now.

Eszel grabbed her terminal, and punched in the instructions in, and they accelerated upwards, the stars vanishing from view.

"Give me the terminal," she snapped, but Lao didn't respond, curled up on the floor. She took a step towards him, feeling her head spin, and leant down.

The recording was still running as she picked it up and flung it at the opposite wall, smashing it. Then, just as the elevator drew to a halt, she grabbed her own terminal, dropped it on the floor, and ground it to fragments beneath her shoe.

They'd still know who'd been down there, of course, but without the recording and the hack, they might not figure out who'd been the ringleader.

Noah shuddered on the floor, and she looked down at him. He looked pale, and had vomited weakly onto his shirt. She should probably be doing something - vague memories of first aid flitted in and out of her mind, but she couldn't remember details.

"Just hold on," she said, her voice dull. "It's going to be fine."

You're getting better at lying, I see.

Eszel's strength failed her just as she punched the physical yellow button on the elevator console.

A shrill alarm screamed, and she collapsed to her knees, doubling over, bile rising in her throat.

It didn't matter. She wasn't afraid.

3

"You didn't know about GUT field excursions, I take it?" said Hansun, voice calm and measured. "Vacuum energy drives are metastable - you know what that means, I assume. Among other things, it means that there are random fluctuations in power, and therefore radiation output. You were all reckless."

"Yes, thank you," Eszel scowled, lip trembling. "It was dumb of us to listen to Noah, but I think I'd figured that one out already. I still miss him."

Act like he's hurt your feelings. I flinched, looking down as if abashed.

"Yes… you and Lao were fortunate to survive, but I suppose neither of you deserved to be blamed simply for following his lead."

"Colonel, was it really necessary to bring this up? That tragedy is long behind us, and I'm sure your bosses are aware of it."

"I'm sorry, but I was asked to go over anything that might be significant."

"Well if you're done, can we move on? I don't enjoy talking about it, and I don't see how it's relevant to anything that happened of Kailash."

"Yes, yes of course…" Hansun trailed off. "The disaster itself. You left the base immediately prior to the tragedy. Why don't you tell me about that."

The Resolute slid into orbit over Kailash with a final burst of thrust from its secondary fusion drives, the mysterious subquantum processes of its main vacuum-energy engine long since stilled to slumber. Eszel stood beside her father, watching through the hyperdiamond-reinforced viewing cupola as a trio of landers detached from the main spine. The interstellar medium shield was a flat disc ahead, the view slowly rotating as she looked down from spin gravity.

Their hails had gone unanswered, and the captain had made the decision to approach while the lead ship of the flotilla, invincible, hung back. They weren't quite a canary in a coalmine, not yet at least.

"Amazing, isn't it?" her father smiled, squeezing her shoulder. "The high frontier, just like in the stories, Essie."

She winced at the name but made herself smile back. "Yeah, Dad. It's something else."

As they watched, the landers pushed away with bursts of fusion rocket thrust, heading down for the surface, the landing site already marked out. Eszel's eyes were drawn to the planet below. Kailash was a world of stark contrasts - vast, rust-colored plains broken by deep, shadowy recesses that plunged into the planet's crust.

"Look there," her father pointed, excitement evident in his voice. "See those arcs? That's what we've been studying in the probe data."

Eszel nodded, watching as fountains of raw material - rock and metal - flew in jets from one pit to another. "Trade," she murmured, remembering the briefings. "They're exchanging resources."

Her father beamed at her. "That's right! Isn't it fascinating? An entirely alien economic system, played out on a planetary scale."

But Eszel was no longer listening. Her attention had been caught by something else, a pattern in the movements of the matter streams that seemed to pulse with a rhythm just beyond her comprehension. For a moment, she thought she heard a whisper, a voice that seemed to emanate from the planet itself.

"Eszel? Are you alright?" Her father's concerned voice broke through her reverie.

She blinked, the strange sensation fading. "I'm fine, Dad. Just... taking it all in."

He nodded, understanding. "It's a lot to process. We're making history here, you know. The first humans to make contact with a truly advanced alien civilization."

Eszel's gaze drifted to the other people in the observation deck. Scientists, military personnel, and a few other civilian family members like herself, all staring in wonder at the alien world below. She felt a sudden, inexplicable sense of separation from them, as if she were observing them from a great distance.

"Dad," she said slowly, "what do you think they're like? The Mimics, I mean."

Her father chuckled. "Well, from what we've seen in the probe images, they look a bit like midgets in greatcoats. But appearances can be deceiving. Their level of technology is... well, it's beyond anything we've ever encountered."

Eszel nodded, remembering the images she'd seen. "They don't seem to understand language, do they? At least, not how we do."

"No, they don't," her father agreed, a note of frustration creeping into his voice. "All our attempts at communication have failed so far. It's as if we're operating on completely different wavelengths."

Different wavelengths. The phrase triggered something in Eszel's mind, a fleeting glimpse of understanding that vanished as quickly as it had come. She shook her head, trying to clear it.

"You okay, sweetie?" Her father asked, concern evident in his voice.

"Yeah, just a bit overwhelmed, I guess," Eszel replied, forcing a smile. "It's a lot to take in."

Her father nodded, giving her shoulder another squeeze. "I know. But think of the opportunities ahead of us. The things we'll learn, the advancements we'll make. This is the chance of a lifetime, Eszel."

As he spoke, Eszel's gaze was drawn back to the planet below. The pulsing rhythm of the matter streams seemed to intensify, and for a moment, she thought she saw patterns forming in the rust-colored plains, complex geometries that seemed to shift and change as she watched.

A voice, barely a whisper, seemed to echo in her mind: “just imagine what’s beneath that surface”.

Eszel blinked, and the patterns vanished, leaving only the stark, alien landscape of Kailash. She glanced at her father, but he was still talking, oblivious to her momentary lapse.

"...and once we establish a base, who knows what we might discover?" he was saying.

Eszel nodded absently, her mind still echoing with the strange whisper.

"Yeah, Dad," she said quietly. "Who knows."

[Bridge scene]

I pursed my lips in mock concentration. Walker Base was unimaginatively named after an unremarkable Union president of several decades ago, whose one memorable achievement was to establish the Science directorate as a permanent subdivision of the Human Defence Fleet. Its design was the mirror of its namesake; drab programmable silicon corridors spat out by some decades old design algorithm, assembled by bots and matter printers.

My first weeks on-base had been dull.

- We go from space scene to her 'escape' and the discussion of the disaster.
- We need an actual disaster scene - probably one base flashback followed by one actual disaster scene
    - Expanded flashbacks of life on the Kailash base offer a contrast to the devastation, develop characters, and show Eszel's corruption.
    - Subtle hints of strange phenomena could foreshadow the disaster and Eszel's connection to the alien environment.
- Scenes could include initial landing, explorations, and encounters with alien life, hinting at Eszel's alienation.
- Detailed exploration of initial contact with the Kailash aliens builds science fiction and cosmic horror elements.
- Scenes could include communication attempts, realization of the technological gap, and the sense of cosmic insignificance.
- Introduction of details about the Kailash system and technology without full explanations provides a foundation for later revelations.
- Eszel's unique reaction to the aliens sets her apart and hints at her future role.

Something like, 'boring base life' scene, she goes outside against rules, meets a mimic, "speaks" or gets some kind of vision. She gets the premonition, that she's oging to be freed or sent out or the base is going to be destroyed. Might need to change later thing so she's more clearly to blame.

Makes some kind of clear decision to leave, the mimics could say something like "we'll show you the way if you leave them to their fate", or similar. She should make it seem like her entire life has been leading to that, so she thinks about it and decides what she

really needs, then they all die in the strike. She’s shocked of course, she didn’t exactly plan for them to die, her parents too. And she’s alone, but she feels like on some level maybe she knew, and we see the lack of grief, but we do see fear and shock and a sense that she did this.

Make 2 sections probably one where the main reveal is that the mimics can talk to her, there’s some wonder, its exciting more than anything else and the second them leading her out. Can use the first to establish the base incidentally a bit more and then the second can lead into her escape but she sees the strike itself and knows she caused it. Then we also change the listener chat to be a bit more revealing.

Then, with it clear that she’s the cause somehow, she follows the path they laid out and the story resumes. Probably we build up to this somewow, but this way we have a clear revelation that she caused this. The mimics communicate with her and no one else, speaking in her own language. Then this builds up to meeting the listener.

One of the problems with understanding people, and Essie felt that she'd always understood people far too well, is that it made it ever so hard to forgive them. Take this colonel. He probably believed himself to be a good and honourable man. It might even be true. Hadn't he been some kind of war hero?

But people weren't so simple. Take the man before her and order him to bombard a planet. Would he say no? Many in his place wouldn't, or hadn't, but Essie would give him the benefit of the doubt. Perhaps he'd hold out.

Threaten him with court martial and life imprisonment, tell him that it was necessary to safeguard the Union, and then what? He'd pull the trigger, no doubt after staging a fit of guilt. And he'd believe himself a good man even as he did it.

Place him among the regimented fortress-keeps of Bastal for a decade and he'd come out as ruthless as any of them. Hand him over to Arco and he'd betray the Union before a year had passed. So who was the man before her, really? A loyal soldier, a stolid fanatic, a kind and good man? No.

He thought he was a good man, but Essie knew better. Which wasn't to say he was bad - Bad wasn't quite the word either. Bad gave him too much credit, too much agency. You didn't call a dog evil if it bit you, nor good if it guarded you.

The man who was neither good nor bad said something to her.

“Why did the Kailash attack Walker base?”

“How should I know? I was too busy running for my life, Colonel.”

“The behaviour you described is… strange. Not consistent with the other reports I’ve seen.”

“Well neither is what they did to the base,” said Eszel. “Maybe you just don’t understand them as well as you thought.”

“Maybe you’re right,” mused Hansun,

“What did it look like? I never saw it up close.”

“Like nothing I’ve ever seen before.”

Eszel glanced down and saw the colonel's tremor had returned.

"Were you scared?" She replied instantly.

Hansun's face was stony.

"Did you have any contact with the Kailash during your weeks away?"

"I saw a few of them. But they seemed to want to avoid me. Guess they only attack when they’ve outnumbered their victim, got them cornered, trapped."

The colonel said nothing.

"Was there any indication of unusual alien activity? Seismic events, tremors, that sort of thing."

"A few earthquakes."

"How many? Can you identify the time and date?"

"You must have seismic readings, why do you need my reports?"

"Corroboration is always-"

"You're trying to catch me out."

The colonel said nothing, giving her a flat stare.

"How many seismic events did you experience?"

Essie knew there had been over a dozen, of course, but the lie was already on her lips.

"I dunno. Four?"

"You're lying."

The directness of the question shocked her, and she found herself grinning. This man wasn't a total pushover after all.

"At least twelve."

4

'Tell me how you came to leave the base Eszel. Do you remember that?'

'Yes, of course.'

Hansun waited, his affect conveying patient anticipation.

'It was three days after the storm.'

'Do you remember the purpose of your excursion?' he pressed.

'Yes. I went to retrieve a drone that dropped out of the network.'

'Alone?'

Something about his interrogative tone suggested I should respond otherwise.

'No, there were two of us, me and ?' I lied easily. Had I ever been alone?

'What time of day was it?'

That question followed quickly – did he suspect?

'It was getting dark. Dusk. We took a Mule out with us, to carry everything. Tools for if repairs were possible, a replacement drone if not. They provide recon, forecasts, network coverage… we spotted the outage – probably just some glitch caused by the storm – '

'You took supplies?' Hansun interrupted.

'Yes. Precaution. Provisions for a week.' Hansun looked briefly concerned, before that not-quite-perfect mask of dispassionate interest slid back down. 'What's this really about?'

Hansun spread his palms, leaning back in his chair in a gesture of open invitation.

'We just want to get to the truth. Just tell me what you can remember.'

But there was no point in telling him the truth, helping him establish facts, compile a timeline. What purpose would it serve? What did the truth matter when he could never understand it?

The truth is I could not have told him why I left the base on the third day after the storm. I didn't know myself. Why did I hang over that precipice when I was young? Why did I go to such lengths to stare out into that rushing void between the stars? Why did anyone do anything?

I left the base because I wanted to. Because I desired solitude, a respite from the constant crushing pressure of being hemmed in with all those other people. Because I was curious. Because there was nothing left for me here. Because something called me to do so and I chose to heed it.

I found myself suddenly awake after yet another bout of fitful sleep, of seamlessly drifting between waking dream and fevered nightmare. I lay there for a moment in the crushing darkness of the simulated diurnal cycle, inhaled deeply and found myself resolved. There was little more to it than that.

I thumbed the room's lights on, blinking as they came up to match the level in the corridor beyond, dimmed though it was in a concession to our circadian rhythm. I crossed to the locker and dressed quickly in my environment suit and a heavy cape designed to provide some degree of further protection from the elements and the ambient radiation. Then I slung the helmet from a strap over my shoulder and without further hesitation, using the handover to the next shift as cover, I made my way to the nearest airlock, pausing only to grab all the provisions I could carry – power packs, a bubble tent, an aquifier, enough rations for two weeks. I was careful to disable any comms. I projected my usual assurance as I slipped from the base – nobody challenged me, nobody asked where I was going with so many supplies.

I secured my helmet and the airlock began to cycle, muffled sounds only growing quieter as the pressure differential equalised. As the incessant background noise of the base dropped away, an almost meditative sense of calm settled over me. Then I was out under the open sky. The heavy door thudded shut behind me, the sound dampened by the thin atmosphere.

Outside, beyond the confines of the base's artificially illuminated rat run, the ghostly blue twilight of the long Kailash dusk was dwindling to darkness, and the bloody-red disk of the eclipsed moon had risen above the opposite horizon. Nobody else even bothered to look up from their work as I strapped my provisions to an idle Mule, too preoccupied with repairing the damaged base – testing the patched mesh, replacing burnt out sensors, checking the radiation shielding was sound – hurriedly rushing to finish the last of the day's work before the protracted night. I set off with a brisk stride,

the Mule, keyed to follow, loping behind. Though some semblance of order had been restored, the expedition was still reeling from the loss of the ?. It would be many hours before someone noted my absence and by the time they committed to a search I would be long gone. No more than thirty minutes after I'd awoken, I'd crossed the outer perimeter.

As I crested one of the low hills overlooking the base, I turned back one last time. I sensed a finality in that moment, something that told me that it was not just the base that I was leaving behind, yet I felt no apprehension. I took it all in – the sprawl of scattered modules, sheltered in that shallow depression, now visible only by their pinprick lights, like some paltry imitation of the stars overhead. A fallen constellation lying tarnished in the dirt. Our mere presence had sullied this place, Kailash, this perfect and timeless wilderness. Our ancestors had never set foot on its namesake, in deference to its sacredness. But modernity, delusional in its faith in its own objectivity, showed no such restraint. Already we sought to bend this discovery to our designs, to find a place for it in our schemes, discarding anything that didn't fit.

Then as I descended the other flank of the hill the base dipped out of view and with that it was as though I was truly alone. I picked my way carefully down the hillside, using only the moon and that fading twilight to illuminate my way.

An epic trek lay ahead of me – over eight-hundred klicks to the fringes of the karst landscapes of the Scab and the nearest cluster of pits – and yet I never held the entire journey in my mind. I never really considered that vast distance from A to B nor what it would take to cross it. My mind was already set. I just kept putting one foot in front of the other and moment by moment the distance between me and the world I was leaving behind grew.

An hour or so into my journey I came to a small stream, not yet frozen over. I followed its course as far as I could, in an attempt to confuse any potential pursuers. The temperature plummeted as the night drew on, but my environmental suit kept me insulated. I stopped only when I could walk no farther, my feet sore, my legs aching. I unpacked the tent in as sheltered a spot as I could find, watching as the orange smart fabric inflated, lit from within by a quantum dot skin. I clambered inside the airtight blister, the membrane parting around me and once the air had warmed inside, at last removed my helmet. The ancillary machinery supporting this tiny microcosm hummed softly outside. I lay back, enwombed, and changed the display from it's default warming light to a view of the sky above, a vista of watchful stars.

The dreams came again that night and each night after, growing more vivid with every passing day. I only call them dreams for lack of a better word… Simulacra? Hallucinations? Visions? All these words convey a sense of unreality, a sense that does not fit the world I found within, there for my discovery, as real as the waking world.

As the nights wore on, I cannot even be sure that I slept. Time passed. I felt rested. I had not left my tent. But in a way that I cannot truly describe I felt as though I had simply crossed over some thinning threshold and continued my journey by a different route. Like a stone skimming over water, except that I was both the stone and its reflection, the stream of my consciousness a sinusoidal wave. As the surface of those black waters stilled, no longer broken by the troubled wake of other people's passing thoughts, the reflected world grew clearer, mirror-like. And with every oscillation, with every cycle, it became less clear to me which world was the reflection. It became less clear to me whether such a distinction even made sense.

I could not say exactly how long I wandered in that arid expanse; I'm sure I could have kept track but for some reason it never occurred to me to do so. Three weeks? A month? What did it matter? My days settled into a steady rhythm, walking for as long as I could in the hours around dawn and dusk, resting during the icy nadir of the long night and the hottest hours of the day when the blinding sun was high overhead.

I lost the Mule at some point in this span. I had looked around one day to find it no longer there. Retracing my steps, I finally found it at the bottom of a narrow ravine, its form twisted and twitching and broken. It seemed more alive in death than it ever had in it stunted mockery of life – I almost felt sorry for it. Maybe some radiation damage to its circuits had caused it to miscalculate and lose its footing. Maybe it had just made a mistake. I salvaged what I could from the wreck, slinging it across my back. Progress after that was even more agonising.

My rations ran low, then dwindled to nothing, until I was subsisting only on the meagre water the aquifier could scrape from the thin air or recycle from the waste products of my body. Occasionally I would cross gullies where water flowed, but I could only carry so much in my canteen.

Each time I resumed my journey I covered less and less ground. Each time I slept I feared that I might never wake. The prospect of surrender to the dreamworld was tempting, but the same singularity of will that had compelled me this far did not abandon me. I could feel myself growing delirious with hypoxia, dehydration and hunger, my vision blurring, my heart pounding in my chest, drowned out only by the gasping shallow breaths I drew. My aching legs and blistered feet pleaded that I stop but I paid them no heed, listening only to the little voice that whispered *just a little further now. Just a little further, you're almost there…*

5

"So, that's how you came to be outside the base," said Hansun. "What I don't understand is, why is your suit recorder blank?"

“I guess I must have switched it off,” said Eszel, arms folded.

“Look,” said Hansun, reasonably. “You’ve got to start giving us something, Essie.”

She frowned; why did people always call her that when they were about to patronize her?

“With respect, Colonel, I’ve given you quite a lot. You’ve hardly left me alone since we broke orbit and all you’ve done is ask me the same questions over and over again.”

“Tell me about the missing 33 days. You were stranded with only a short-duration oxygenator, which doesn’t seem to have been used for more than five hours.”

“I replaced the unit about five hours before the rescue arrived,” she said, gaze steady.

“What did you eat?”

“Alien environment suits have protein reprocessors. I fed in local plants.”

“That is an interesting answer, because it almost makes sense. One of the projects the forward base was working on when the last report was received was reconfiguring a protein reprocessor to work with Kailash organics. At last report, it wasn’t going well.”

“The team working on it made a breakthrough. My father is… was, a very clever man.”

The corporal smiled kindly, just as someone would act if they had to talk to a traumatized child, but it didn’t reach his eyes. Eszel noticed him twitch slightly and wondered if she’d said something wrong. That was what had happened; she knew with iron certainty.

“I’m sure he was, and I know this must be difficult for you, but your father was a plasma physicist. His last mission log described some inconsistencies in the behaviour of the incandescent matter in the pit light tubes, which suggested the circulating ions were having their inertial mass altered. He didn’t have anything to do with the protein reprocessors.”

Eszel’s face screwed up for a moment in anger as a tear ran down her face; she wiped her eyes furiously with a sleeve and when she looked up at the corporal her face was red.

“I’m not a liar and I don’t care what you think of me. My father died just before building the machine that saved my life. Do you want me to deny that for your record?”

‘That’s not what I meant at all, I’m just trying to ascertain-‘

She had him off-balance now, just a final push, and it would all be fine.

'My father was a wonderful, brilliant, clever man, and he saved my life. I'm not saying any different, not to you and not to anyone else.'

The last few meters of the tunnel were a hard scramble. I pulled myself up with some difficulty, arms flailing for a moment as I tried to gain purchase on the scree. No way I could have managed it under a standard gravity.

Suddenly, there was another hand in mine, pulling me up to safety. I caught a glimpse of a silhouetted figure standing over me, and then I was being hauled abruptly to the surface by someone strong.

Why wasn't I surprised?

I should have been shocked but somehow, for some strange reason, it felt very natural - something must lie at the end of my journey, and now here he was.

With a final jolt, I came to rest on the bare earth, in the open air, and looked up at my rescuer.

The man stood before me, floating? Resting? He was about half a meter off the ground; pale-skinned and blandly handsome, maybe only a few years older than me, and as anonymous as anyone I'd ever seen.

I opened my mouth, but something stopped me. This wasn't a time for flippant remarks.

I studied the newcomer while reaching to wipe dust away from the suit visor, searching for any hint of strangeness in his face. There was none, aside from the fact of his existence, standing untouched on the twilit, radiation-blitzed surface of Kailash, where no other human could be.

Had I finally cracked; had the relief ships arrived weeks early? I'd always thought hallucinations weren't supposed to be this consistent and well-defined, yet he was casting a shadow. Perhaps he wasn't a normal hallucination, but some effect of the inertial fields the Kailash channelled beneath the ground, the same fields that had doomed the outpost I'd just barely escaped from.

I looked into his eyes, and, despite their absolute ordinariness, found I had trouble meeting them. Still, the apparition waited. We stood, him and I, a few paces apart, quiet and still.

Slowly, I glanced down at the softscreen on my arm and flicked through the displays; the med readout noted high cortisol, high heart rate and nothing else out of the ordinary; the low-res EF-scan registered nothing abnormal in my brain; unless that was also a hallucination. I looked up; the man was still there.

'Who are you?' I said. It was hardly a question, because how could he answer? The air up here was too thin to transmit sound, so the suit speakers didn't kick in. He heard me anyway; that inert face broke into a surprisingly warm smile, and he reached out his arms towards me.

'I think you already know,' he said, sounding as though he stood right next to me. I checked, saw the suit recorder's flat trace. His voice sounded real enough.

Hesitantly, I reached up and took his outstretched hand. The hand felt solid. Then, it was as if sense finally returned, and I snatched it away.

'Tell me who you are,' I demanded.

'Words are strange things,' the man mused, and something about him compelled me to listen, the infinite patience. 'Folding a concept down, flattening it to fit inside bursts of compressed air. Detail is always lost. I am no-one; what you should be asking is, what am I?'

'Okay,' I said, narrowing my eyes. 'What are you?'

The man shrugged.

'Everything. I am the space between the stars and the ground beneath your feet.'

He didn't say it like a boast. He said it like it was ordinary, like that was his job description.

'So, what, I'll call you mister everything? Why don't you give me a real answer?'

'Call me the Listener, if it helps,' his lips quirked up.

I'd had enough of being played with, and reached forward, poking him in the centre of this chest.

The Listener wore a grey suit of an old-fashioned cut; he didn't pitch backwards, even by the tiniest degree, as if he were anchored to the worlds' mass. Or the world was anchored to him.

‘Is that proof enough?’ he said. ‘It’s as much evidence as you’ll get, so why not work with me on this? What is real but what you judge to be real? It’s not like there’s anyone here who’ll disagree with you.’

“You’re trying to persuade me to trust you?”

“No, of course not,” the man laughed. “I don’t need to.”

You’re confident. I’ll give you that.

I thought for a moment before I replied. He clearly wanted me to realize something.

"You said I already know you? I suppose that makes you that impulse - the one in my head?”

He nodded.

“A little extra push here and there - *lean over a balcony*, *go see a window*. Things to make you think, to realize who you are.”

So I suppose I must be going mad.

“You're, what, my hidden conscience?"

He laughed.

"I don't think that quite fits, Essie. Perhaps it's close enough.”

"Then tell me why I should trust you."

"You already trust me, Essie. Have I ever led you astray?"

I thought briefly about the other times in my life where, with hindsight, it seemed like I had been driven on by something inexplicable.

"Well, I'm about to die. Does that count?"

"Some people believe that death is salvation.”

"Yeah, I'm sure they do. But I don't.”

“You’re not afraid of death, Eszel - you never have been. It just took you a little while to realize that.”

“You’re wrong,” I said it, but I didn’t believe it.

“Look at what you’ve done, Eszel. Step back and just look, imagine someone is watching you and consider how you might appear from the outside. Be honest.”

What had I done? I’d gone out on this pilgrimage alone, caring nothing for the danger, not even *thinking* about it. How had I done that? What was I?

I tried to imagine the steps that had taken me here, tried to figure out what had driven me onward, and something hollow opened up in me. He was right, truly and entirely. This whole time, from the very beginning, I’d never been afraid. What did that mean?

“That you aren’t ordinary. That you’re capable of things that would make most people collapse in on themselves and surrender,” the Listener interjected.

I didn’t bother asking if he could read my mind. Dumb question.

“So where do we go from here?”

The Listener gave an ambivalent shrug, and looked at me, expectantly. I met his gaze, with some effort. He was going to make me say it.

“Does that mean you won't help? Me, I mean,’ I threw my hands out theatrically. I’m in a bit of a bind here.’

'What do you expect me to do?'

'I don't know. Do you have a comm? Calling for help might be a good start.'

'Suppose I did. Suppose they burned hard to get here. What then?'

'I'd wait.'

'Your reprocessors wouldn't hold out, Essie. You'd be dead within fifteen days. Maybe sooner, considering your… state."

"So that's it? I die out here, stuck with *you*? You'd let that happen?"

"No."

Essie narrowed her eyes. The listener looked down at her, expression passive.

Does he want me to beg?

"Help me," she said. "I trust you."

"No matter what I decide to do?"

The listener was suddenly serious, any trace of levity gone.

"Yes."

Everything went black. A thick, heavy darkness bloomed around Eszel, shot through with sudden bursts of gleaming white, traceries that completed themselves, forming weblike patterns, structures that shifted and interpenetrated, burning with luminance.

It was overwhelming, terrible and beautiful, too complex to understand, too bright to see, too loud to hear. It overwhelmed her, yet she couldn't look away. She tried to scream, and heard nothing but that eternal raw light.

The pattern bloomed like a flower, growing more complex, more incomprehensible, with each new second. And somehow Eszel knew that this was the way the Listener saw the world, that within this web was everything, that she herself had just begun to understand something true and fundamental, to see things the way that he did. Time passed.

She saw an unseen hand, a tweak, and the burning light-webs shifted, strings snapping, unravelling and changing, configurations shifting. Physicality returned and she was flung to somewhere, the roaring in her ears subsiding, ground and sky and gravity returning. She was back on Kailash.

Eszel staggered backwards, a flood of static bombarding her suit radio and turning into screeching feedback.

She shouted, tripping and falling to the ground.

A second later, the suit triangulated on the target; one of the emergency beacons in the collapsed base had warmed itself up and screeched out its report. Her legs ached beneath her, as if she'd just run a marathon, and something slid over the sky, casting a sharp shadow. The local sun had jumped clear across the sky, from twilight to noonday.

She reeled, some part of her still searching for the Listener, eyes dashing out towards distant ditches and rock formations as if he might appear again. Then she looked up and saw a HDF navy landing craft descending through the blue-black sky on spikes of thermal thrust. She was hallucinating, then. No relief ships arriving for months; that had been the defining fact of her life ever since the outposts' destruction.

It took a few moments before she noticed the time displayed on her HUD. In the moment Listener vanished, more than three weeks had passed.

Hansun tensed, but he seemingly decided to drop the issue. He stood up from the chair, turning briskly to leave.

"Once again - I'm so sorry for putting you through this. Someone will be here to bring you food in the next few minutes."

"When are you going to let me out?" she said coldly.

'Soon, I promise.'

"When we get back home, I'll remember what you've said, all the lies you've told me."

He flinched, which surprised her a little. She forced herself to not smile as he turned away. She was still in shock, after all. There was no possibility that she was glad to have gotten one over on the young officer. She missed the dead, her parents, her friends, all very much. She'd said so, hadn't she? Behind the retreating corporal, an unreal young man lounged against the wall, beaming at her. The Listener nodded his approval and vanished like a bad special effect.

Epilogue

It was over. Hansun walked through the corridors of the HDFS Invincible, feeling the deck vibrate beneath his feet. The corridors were nearly empty now, with all but a skeleton crew returned to their cryogenic berths. They were still on conventional fusion power, slowly running diagnostics on the massive, slow-to-rouse conversion drive that would soon propel them home at constant acceleration.

The monopole-boosted drive, courtesy of Arco and leased to the HDF, would take them back to network-connected space and civilization. It would still take two years. Two years of being stuck on the same ship as that girl. No matter that she was currently frozen and inert, a hundred meters below Hansun's feet. It spooked him, and even now he couldn't quite say why.

He didn't want to admit it, even in the privacy of his own mind, but he didn't like Eszel. She was traumatized, surely, even if she had an odd way of showing it. But he was also sure she was hiding something. It was just obvious that her story made no sense and yet no-one, least of all the Captain, seemed to care enough about how she'd survived her ordeal to investigate further.

Why am I so suspcious?

It was like a huge part of him simply wanted to forget, carry on as normal, but he couldn't quite do it.

Whenever he'd asked her a question it felt as though she were x-raying him; she never gave straight answers to the big questions, and somehow he always walked away with

nothing worth reporting. She seemed to lie about trivial things with utter sincerity, so much so that he often walked away trusting her word over the evidence.

Sometimes she glanced over his shoulder at nothing, or smiled at inappropriate moments. Although she'd cried plenty after being picked up and thanked us time and time again for saving her, she'd never seemed close to truly losing control. The ship's psychologist said she was just processing the fear and survivor guilt, but that didn't quite fit with what he'd seen. It was like she just wasn't too bothered by what had happened, but hadn't quite realized it yet. He supposed there wasn't any other way to put it. There was something wrong with Eszel.

It was evening. Hansun was in his quarters, far wall set to imitate the rugged landscape of one of Deliverances' outermost moons, a few scattered positive-pressure buildings underneath the blue of a thin nitrogen-oxygen atmosphere.

The big display portal was showing a rerun of a century old Oskar Nozoka drama - the melodramatic speculative thriller had always helped him disconnect from reality, and had been a guilty pleasure of his ever since he was a child.

The final post-mission briefing and laser transmission to the interstice was tomorrow, and then, the day after so far as he'd perceive it, he'd be coughing up revival fluid and trying to remember how to walk, back home aboard the Deliverance naval anchorage.

It was over, and nothing had been resolved.

Would they get a hero's welcome? What for? Simply for surviving and learning damn near nothing in the process?

Hansun rubbed his temples, closing his eyes briefly. The program continued, Oskar brandishing a pulsar rifle at a horde of vicious pre-sentient Dyn, shouting that they would pay for their crimes.

Then the program cut off, mid-line. Hansun opened his eyes. There was a red priority message blinking on the display. It was from the admiral.

Ten minutes later he was dressed in full uniform and standing in the CIC of the Invincible, which was darkened and empty, aside from the admiral. Most of the surviving senior crew were already in storage deep within the vessel's suspension chambers. The circular area around the volumetric display reminded him uncomfortably of the Isidore.

The admiral turned his hawklike face away from a console, eyeing Hansun.

"Hope I didn't disturb you, colonel."

“No sir.”

“I would think you’d be glad to have some R&R after what I put you through.”

“The evac went fairly smoothly in the end, sir. Though I’m sorry we never got answers.”

“I meant the girl. I’ve heard she’s a handful.”

Hansun laughed, unsure if the admiral was joking or not.

“You’re wrong, you know. The other thing you said,” the Admiral turned away from his console, staring at Hansun across the volumetric display. “I found some answers.”

Hansun’s heart quickened.

“And that’s why you brought me here?”

The Admiral nodded, waving a hand and calling up a volumetric plot of the Kailash system.

“I had the ship’s general system analysing those anomalous coronal events, the ones we determined were synchronised with the fist-of-god events.”

“Is that what we’re calling it - the gravity weapon?”

The admiral shrugged, leaning over the display.

“It’s as good a name as any other. Anyway,” he waved his hand and the display shifted, showing filtered ultraviolet views of the local star, the swells of plasma bursting from its surface.

“There were two major events, one associated with the destruction of the base and the other our sister ship in orbit. Magnetic flux lines pinching as part of the surface deforms inward at extreme speed, as if its being hollowed out from the inside. The system tells me it's consistent with a vacuum cavity opening up, somewhere within the convective zone and matter falling in to fill the gap. Enormous star quakes, rapid shift in field lines - final proof that this is not normal solar weather.”

“The star’s being siphoned? With what, one of those Arcan plasma extractors? We would have detected a solarwell, those things are huge and damn near impossible to hide.”

The admiral smiled.

“Ah, but there was no solarwell, nothing physical. It’s as if a thousand cubic kilometers of solar plasma simply vanished from the star’s convective zone, almost as if it was moved.”

“A wormhole,” Hansun breathed. “They’ve got a wormhole inside the star?”

“Indeed. Hot convective zone plasma is being removed - likely via a wormhole gate, likely to provide power.”

Hansun flicked the display around, glancing at a time series plot showing the starquakes and coronal mass ejections, the radiation emission spectrum rising and falling after each gravitational event on the planet.

“Where did the plasma go? We’d have seen it bursting out of the ground on Kailash like a nuclear explosion.”

“It wasn’t siphoned to Kailash. That was the second thing I found.”

The map shifted again, displaying tagged objects crowding the distant edges of the system - clusters of comets in the inner Oort cloud.

“It’s taken weeks for the light to arrive, but I think I know where that plasma went. Watch.”

The Admiral advanced the display, and all of a sudden, right across the map, twelve of the comets flared with brilliant radiation. Hansun started. They’d flashed like Christmas lights, coordinated and instantaneous, and - he checked the light-delay, at exactly the same moment as the weapon had fired.

“This whole system is an engine, silent-running and stealthy, but an engine nonetheless. Solar plasma is relayed by wormhole, converted to some more usable form of energy inside these distant structures, then relayed back to the inner planets by more wormholes. This entire system is probably criss-crossed with them, stitched up into one great machine.”

And this entire time, we’ve been blundering through it without the slightest idea of what we were facing, Hansun thought.

“So we at least know how the weapon was powered, sir,” Hansun said. “I don’t understand, why the secrecy?”

Aumonier didn’t look up, too absorbed in his display. He magnified one of the distant flaring comets, expanding the image and adding in enhancement and visual inference filters. Slowly the structure built up, and Hansun choked off as he realized what he was seeing.

The Other Moon?

An almond-shaped, grey-brown structure, superficially like an asteroid in appearance, but too regular, too symmetrical, unmistakable as a prehistoric hand-axe. The indisputable product of intelligent engineering.

Aumonier flicked the display, showing another 'comet', which had an identical shape, and another, and another.

"A dozen Other Moons, colonel. The greatest treasure trove of technology in all history. And the most powerful weapon of them all. With one of these, the ancient Dyn broke the Utilitaria. With ten…"

Hansun saw Aumonier's thought then, and suppressed a shudder.

"With ten, there would be no limits to our power.